

ANANTA: THE INFINITE CYCLE



HET KIKANI

**ANANTA:
THE INFINITE
CYCLE**

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PROLOGUE



The First Glitch

The rain did not wash the world clean; it tried to erase it.

It hammered against the sandstone walls of the Red Fort, a relentless, rhythmic drumming that sounded less like weather and more like a clock counting down. The water sluiced over the carved parapets, spitting violently onto the slick marble balcony where Rishi Malhotra stood. He gripped the marble railing, his knuckles bone-white against the dark, wet stone. The chill of the rain seeped through his soaked cotton tunic, plastering it to his heavy muscles, but he didn't step back into the dry warmth of the room behind him. He squeezed the marble until the joints in his hands throbbed, desperate to ground himself in something solid.

To the empire, he was "The Unbreaking Shield," the Rajput General who had never lost a campaign. He commanded tens of thousands of men, orchestrating death across the Northern Plains of the Mughal Empire four hundred years ago. But tonight, he was a man holding onto his sanity by a thread.

Inside the Queen's private chambers behind him, the air was thick, suffocatingly sweet with the scent of crushed jasmine and the sharp, copper tang of wet iron. It was an oppressive heat that coated the back of his throat.

Rishi looked out at the courtyard below. Torches flickered erratically in the storm, hissing as raindrops struck the hot oil, casting long, violent shadows across the muddy flagstones. He waited for the next strike of lightning to illuminate the garrison.

A jagged tear of white light ripped across the black sky.

But when the lightning flashed, Rishi didn't see the massive, tethered war elephants or the lines of armored guards.

For a split second—a heartbeat that felt like an agonizing eternity—the stone courtyard flickered.

The physical world broke. The ancient masonry simply dissolved into a stark, humming grid of neon blue lines. The

massive, breathing elephants warped and collapsed in on themselves, becoming hulking, geometric shapes of polished chrome and thick, black rubber.

Rishi gasped, stumbling backward. The heel of his leather boot caught the edge of a wet Persian rug. He threw a hand out, catching the stone archway. His heart hammered wildly against his ribs, a frantic, trapped rhythm.

He looked up. Above the heavy storm clouds, where only eagles should dare to fly, he saw the silhouette of a massive metal bird screaming across the sky, leaving a distinct, unnatural trail of white smoke in its wake. The mechanical roar vibrated in his teeth, drowning out the thunder.

And then, the thunder rolled over the valley, and the courtyard snapped back. The stone returned. The elephants shifted uneasily in the mud. The sky was just black clouds and rain.

Rishi squeezed his eyes shut, pressing the heels of his hands hard against his eye sockets until colors bloomed in the darkness.

"It is the fever," he whispered to himself, his voice a dry, panicked rasp. "Just the fever of war".

"You are tired, my General."

The voice was soft, velvet wrapped around a dagger.

Rishi flinched. He dropped his hands and turned around slowly, the wet cotton of his tunic clinging uncomfortably to his spine.

Queen Mehrunissa sat upon her low, cushioned divan, bathed in the erratic, golden glow of a dozen brass oil lamps. She was terrifyingly beautiful, her dark eyes heavily rimmed with thick black kohl, her silk robes the exact color of a bruised sunset. The fabric pooled elegantly around her feet. She held a heavy gold goblet of wine, her gaze fixed entirely on him with a soft pity that made his skin crawl.

She looked perfectly composed. Safe. Sane.

"I am not tired, my Queen," Rishi replied, his voice trembling despite his rigid military discipline.

He stepped away from the cold air of the balcony, putting distance between himself and the impossible visions outside. The heat of the oil lamps hit him immediately.

"I am... no, it is the marsh water from the eastern plains," he stammered, rubbing his jaw. "It lingers in the blood. It makes the mind see..." He stopped. He swallowed hard, staring at the intricate patterns woven into the rug. "I am... remembering".

Mehrunissa froze. The deep red wine in her goblet stilled entirely, completely defying the slight, natural tremor in her

hand.

"Remembering what, Rishi?" she asked quietly.

"Things that have not happened yet," he said, the impossible words spilling out of him like dark blood from a fresh wound.

He took a hesitant step toward her, his hands gesturing vaguely, desperately trying to articulate the madness. "I see lines of light on the ground. I see towers. Not stone, Mehrunissa. Towers of glass piercing the heavens".

He pressed two fingers to his temple, digging into the skin.

"I see men in white coats trapped in small, cold blue rooms". He looked at her, his eyes wide and bloodshot. "And a sound. A machine sound. I hear the word, Mehrunissa. Over and over again in the thunder".

He took another step toward the divan, his boots tracking wet mud onto the pristine carpets.

"What is Ananta?" he demanded.

The atmosphere in the room shifted instantly.

It wasn't a draft from the open balcony. It was a violent,

physical plunge in temperature. The stifling warmth of the oil lamps vanished completely, replaced by a sudden, biting chill that seeped directly into his bones. The heavy shadows pooling in the corners of the bedchamber seemed to elongate, stretching across the walls toward him like dark, grasping fingers.

Mehrunissa slowly set the heavy gold goblet down on a low wooden table. The metal clunked dully against the wood.

When she looked up, the warmth and the familiar love in her kohl-rimmed eyes were entirely gone, replaced by an ancient, hollow deadness. It was the look of a void.

"You were the best of them, Rishi," she said.

Rishi staggered back a half-step. Her voice was wrong. It was distorting, layering over itself with a metallic rasp, as if two entirely different people were speaking the exact same words a fraction of a second apart.

"The bravest," the layered voices continued, devoid of any human inflection. "The most loyal. I thought you would be content with the illusion".

"Illusion?" Rishi whispered. The word caught in his dry throat. His hand instinctively drifted downward, his calloused fingers wrapping around the familiar, leather-wrapped hilt of his curved talwar. "What did you give me?

In the wine tonight... what have you done to me?"

"I gave you paradise," she hissed, the sound sharp and synthetic. "I gave you a war you could always win and a love that would never die".

She stood up from the divan.

As she moved, her physical form suddenly and violently blurred—a visual stutter of gray static interference exactly like an old, broken screen. The silk robes, the kohl, the skin—it all scrambled into pixelated noise for a horrifying fraction of a second before snapping painfully back into focus.

"But you..." she said, her dead eyes locking onto his. "You had to look at the strings".

The terror in Rishi's chest finally ignited into pure, soldierly rage.

"Guards!" Rishi roared. The command tore at his throat, echoing loudly off the high stone ceiling.

He drew his sword. The heavy, curved steel sang a sharp, violent note as it cleared the scabbard. He leveled the tip at her chest, his stance wide, his breathing heavy and fast.

"Stay back," he warned, his voice dropping to a lethal

growl.

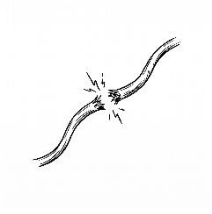
And then came the sound.

A massive, splintering crash.

The heavy wooden doors burst open.

ACT I:
THE NOISE IN THE
MACHINE

CHAPTER 1



The Glitch

The rain did not fall; it assaulted the city.

Outside the reinforced glass walls of the Verma Institute of Quantum Sciences, the Mumbai monsoon was a relentless, drowning gray. It hammered against the pane in thick sheets, blurring the distant, neon-stained skyline of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link into a weeping watercolor painting. Out there, it was a mess of screaming metal and wet concrete—horns blaring, tires screeching, humanity struggling against the deluge.

Inside, the silence was absolute.

It was a sterile, pressurized silence. The kind that made the inner ear ache if you sat still long enough. The only sound permitted in the space was the low, throbbing hum

of the server banks lining the walls. They blinked in the dark. Cool, indifferent blues and greens, reflecting off the polished obsidian floor like the eyes of sleeping predators. The air was mechanically scrubbed clean, heavily recycled, and locked at a precise eighteen degrees Celsius. It smelled of sharp ozone and the bitter dregs of expensive coffee.

Dr. Arjun Verma did not hear the rain. He did not feel the chill.

He lay slumped over his mahogany desk. His cheek was pressed hard against a messy sprawl of holographic blueprints and star charts printed on stiff acetate. A half-empty mug of black coffee sat near his elbow. The dark liquid vibrated slightly, catching the frequency of the room. In the dim light of the monitors, he looked less like the brilliant physicist the world celebrated on magazine covers and more like a man haunting his own life. His eyes were open, staring at nothing.

Clang.

The sound existed only in his head. It wasn't the hum of a server. It wasn't distant thunder.

It was the sharp, violent ring of metal striking metal. A heavy tulwar crashing against a buckler shield.

Arjun gasped, jerking upright. His chair screeched against

the obsidian floor—a harsh, ugly sound that tore through the lab's quiet. He clutched his chest. His breath came in ragged, shallow heaves, scraping against his dry throat. Sweat made his white dress shirt cling to his skin like a second, suffocating layer. He looked frantically around the lab, his pupils blown wide, searching for an enemy that physics dictated could not exist.

"Just a dream," he whispered, his voice cracking on the dry air. He rubbed his face with trembling hands, pressing his palms into his eye sockets. "Just a wired, caffeine-fueled dream."

But it didn't feel like a dream.

Dreams fade. You wake up, and the logic of the dream dissolves like sugar in hot water. This stuck. The physical sensation of the impact was still vibrating deep within his radius bone. And the smell. The smell of the dream—copper, sour sweat, and burning horsehair—lingered in his nostrils, entirely overpowering the sterile scent of the lab. It felt less like imagination and more like a memory he hadn't earned.

He pushed himself up. His legs were unsteady. He walked toward the center of the room.

There, bathed in the soft, worshipful glow of the overhead spots, stood the Ananta Device.

It was a monstrosity of brass and chrome. A massive, rotating iris that looked less like a particle accelerator and more like a gateway. It was the culmination of ten years of work. Billions in funding. And the slow, methodical destruction of his marriage.

He reached out. His hand trembled.

"Focus," he muttered, grinding his teeth together. "Observe. Quantify."

He extended his fingers toward the cold metal of the console.

For a split second, the air around his fingers seemed to shimmer, exactly like heat haze on a tarmac.

He blinked.

In that fraction of a second, his hand wasn't a hand anymore. It was encased in a heavy gauntlet of rusted iron, stained with wet mud and drying blood. The skin of his wrist was raw, chafed bloody by thick leather straps.

He recoiled with a guttural shout, stumbling back away from the console. He stared at his own palm, turning it over and over. The skin was smooth. Modern. Unscarred. The manicured hand of a scientist, not a soldier.

"Arjun?"

The voice was muffled, sounding heavy and distant, as if coming from underwater.

He spun around.

Aditi stood by the glass double doors. She was beautiful, but her image was distorted by the rain streaming down the glass wall behind her. She wore a trench coat dripping with rainwater, her dark hair plastered wetly to her forehead. She looked at him with that familiar, heartbreaking mix of love and absolute terror that had become her default expression lately.

"You're doing it again," she said. Her voice trembled as she stepped into the lab. The automatic doors hissed shut behind her, sealing the pressurized silence once more. "You're talking to yourself. In languages that don't exist anymore."

Arjun quickly lowered his hand, gripping the sharp edge of the console to hide the tremor in his fingers.

"I'm close, Aditi," he said, his voice flat. He stared at the brass iris. "I can feel it. The origin point."

"Close to what?" Aditi walked toward him. The wet

squelch of her boots on the obsidian floor was the only real sound in the room. "Arjun, look at yourself. You haven't been home in three days. You smell like... you smell like you've been burning."

"I have to finish this calibration," Arjun said. He turned back to the glowing screens, refusing to look at her. If he looked at her, he might break. "The resonance frequency is off by 0.04 percent. If I can just"

"Stop it!"

She grabbed his arm, spinning him around. Her grip was surprisingly strong. Her eyes were red-rimmed and exhausted.

"You are hurting yourself!" she cried. "Look at you! You wake up screaming every night. You have scars on your back that weren't there when we went to sleep! You're chasing ghosts, Arjun! You are destroying us for ghosts!"

"Not ghosts," Arjun murmured. He pulled his arm away, gently but firmly. His eyes drifted past her, fixing on a dark shadow in the corner of the room that seemed to be actively watching him. "Past lives. Future echoes. It's all the same data, just corrupted."

"It's schizophrenia, Arjun! It's a breakdown!" Aditi stepped back, wiping angry tears from her face with a wet sleeve. "Please. Come home. Let me call Dr. Rao. Let's just..."

let's just turn the machines off."

Arjun looked at the Ananta Device. The brass iris seemed to be breathing in the blue light, expanding and contracting. It wanted to be opened. It needed to be opened.

"I can't," he said softly. "If I stop now, the noise in my head... it will never stop. I have to know why I remember dying, Aditi. I have to know why I remember holding a sword before I ever learned to hold a pen."

"Arjun, don't"

He slammed his hand onto the activation console.

ENTER.

The hum of the servers spiked instantly into a scream. The sound was physical—a solid wall of pressure that knocked the breath out of them. The Ananta Device spun rapidly. The massive brass iris dilated.

The cool, clinical blue light of the lab exploded into a blinding white.

"Arjun!" Aditi screamed, reaching for him through the glare.

But the world shifted. Violently. Impossibly.

The white light didn't fade; it curdled. The room turned into a deep, blood-soaked Saffron. The temperature in the lab skyrocketed, baking the air. The smell of ozone and coffee vanished, replaced instantly by the acrid stench of sulfur, wet earth, and rotting flowers. The glass walls of the Verma Institute seemed to physically peel away like burning film. They didn't reveal the Mumbai skyline, but a chaotic battlefield under a burning, merciless sun.

And then, the pain hit.

Arjun screamed. It wasn't a sound of shock; it was the guttural roar of a dying animal. A sharp, diagonal line of pure agony ripped across his chest.

He looked down.

His white lab coat tore open as if sliced by an invisible razor. Wet redness bloomed rapidly across the fabric, soaking the cotton. The pain was searing, hot and terribly specific—the distinct feeling of a heavy curved blade carving directly through muscle and bone.

He fell hard to his knees, clutching the phantom wound. Blood—real, hot, sticky blood—seeped rapidly between his fingers.

"Arjun! Stop it! Turn it off!" Aditi screamed.

But her voice was fading. It was being dragged away by the dry wind of a different century. She was becoming translucent before his eyes, a ghost from the future haunting his past.

"You were never meant to wake up."

The whisper cut through the noise of the machine and the scream of the wind like a knife. It was calm. Imperial.

Arjun looked up, gasping for air, his hands slick with his own blood.

Standing in the absolute center of the saffron storm, completely untouched by the chaos, was a woman. She did not wear a lab coat. She wore shifting robes that seemed to be woven directly from smoke and starlight. Her face was ageless, her expression locked in profound, terrifying sorrow.

The Oracle looked down at him with a pity that terrified him far more than the agonizing pain in his chest.

"The glitch is being corrected," she said. Her lips did not move. The voice didn't come from her mouth; it resonated directly in his skull.

Arjun tried to crawl toward the console, desperate to reverse the sequence, but his limbs were heavy, turning to

cold stone. The floor beneath him—the polished obsidian of the lab—began to dissolve into coarse sand.

"Who... are... you?" Arjun wheezed. Blood bubbled hot and metallic on his lips.

"I am the ending," The Oracle replied.

She raised a hand. Her palm glowed with a soft, blinding white light.

The lab, Aditi, the rain, the Ananta Device—it all shattered. The world broke into fractal shards of light, spinning violently away into the void.

"Sleep, Arjun."

CHAPTER 2



The Anchor

The automatic glass double doors of the laboratory hissed shut, sealing the pressurized vacuum of the room and cutting off the dull, ambient roar of the Mumbai monsoon.

Water dripped from the hem of Aditi's trench coat. It hit the polished obsidian floor with a wet, rhythmic *smack*. Once. Twice. A small, dark puddle began to form around her boots, entirely ruining the sterile perfection of the Verma Institute.

She stood just inside the threshold, holding a white plastic bag from the Irani café down the street. The bag was translucent, clinging to a square cardboard box. The faint, greasy smell of cold mutton samosas and damp paper managed to cut through the sharp, metallic bite of the lab's ozone filters.

Arjun remained frozen near the central console. He was still staring at his own hand.

The phantom weight of the rusted iron gauntlet was gone, but the skin of his wrist felt impossibly hot. He rubbed it absentmindedly with his thumb, applying hard, bruising pressure to an injury that wasn't there.

"Arjun."

Her voice didn't echo. The acoustic dampening panels in the ceiling swallowed the sound immediately, making the word drop flat and heavy between them.

He didn't look up. If he looked at her, he would have to acknowledge the reality of the room. He would have to admit that the swords, the blood, and the smell of burning horsehair were just misfiring synapses in a failing brain.

"I brought food," she said. She shifted her weight. The wet rubber of her boot squeaked against the floor. "You didn't answer your phone. I called... I don't know. Seven times."

"I was running a diagnostic." His voice was a dry rasp. He cleared his throat, the sound rough like sandpaper. "The comms array interferes with the magnetic containment field. I had to shut the network down."

"For three days?"

He finally looked at her.

Aditi looked awful. It wasn't just the wet, plastered hair or the smeared eyeliner at the corners of her eyes. It was a bone-deep, gray exhaustion that hollowed out her cheeks. She was thirty-two, but standing there under the harsh, clinical glare of the LED spots, she looked a decade older. She looked like a woman who had spent the last seventy-two hours jumping at every unexpected shadow, waiting for a hospital to call.

She walked slowly toward the primary workstation. She didn't look at the Ananta Device. She actively avoided looking at it. Instead, she set the damp plastic bag down on a clear patch of the mahogany desk, carefully pushing aside a stack of star charts. The cardboard box inside the bag was already soggy.

"Eat," she said. It wasn't a request.

Arjun took a breath. The air felt heavy, dragging in his lungs like wet cotton. He stepped away from the console and walked over to the desk. He didn't reach for the food. He reached for his half-empty mug of cold coffee, taking a slow sip. It tasted like battery acid and old pennies.

"I can't eat right now, Ad." He set the mug down so hard a few drops spilled over the rim, staining a piece of acetate.

"I'm in the middle of a sequence. The resonance frequency is off by a fraction. Zero-point-zero-four percent. It's a rounding error, but it's compounding. If I don't isolate the variable—"

"You're bleeding."

Arjun stopped. "What?"

Aditi pointed a trembling finger at his chest.

He looked down. He wasn't wearing his lab coat; it was draped over the back of his chair. He was just in his white dress shirt. Right over his sternum, near the fourth button, was a small, vivid smear of dark red.

Arjun touched it. His fingertips came away tacky. Blood.

Panic flared, hot and sharp, in the back of his neck. *The sword. The strike.* But then he felt the dull throb at the edge of his jaw. He reached up. A deep, jagged scratch ran along his jawline, crusted with dried blood. He had done it himself. An hour ago. Two hours ago? He had been pacing, tearing his fingernails into his own skin without realizing it, trying to dig the phantom sounds out of his head.

"I scratched myself," he muttered, dropping his hand. He looked away, focusing entirely on the blinking cursor of a nearby monitor. "It's nothing. Just... stress. The dry air in

here."

Aditi didn't move. She stared at the smear on his shirt. Her chest rose and fell in a jagged, uneven rhythm.

"I woke up at three in the morning yesterday," she said softly. She wasn't looking at him anymore. She was looking at the puddle of water expanding around her boots. "The storm was so loud. The wind was hitting the bedroom window. I rolled over to wake you up because the glass was rattling."

She swallowed hard. A physical tick. A hesitation before the drop.

"The bed was cold, Arjun. It was so cold I thought... I don't know what I thought. I got up. I walked through the house. I turned on every single light. The kitchen, the hallway, your study. I stood in the middle of the living room at 4:00 AM, holding a heavy brass candlestick because I thought someone had broken in and taken you."

"Aditi, I left a note on the counter "

"There was no note!"

Her voice cracked, snapping sharply into the quiet room. She took a step toward him, her hands balling into fists at her sides.

"There was no note, Arjun! There hasn't been a note in months! You just leave! You disappear into this... this vault!" She gestured wildly toward the Ananta Device. The massive brass iris caught the movement, reflecting a distorted, warped version of her in its curved metal. "You lock yourself in here with this machine, and you stop existing!"

Arjun shrank back slightly, pressing his hips against the edge of the mahogany desk. The sharp wooden corner dug painfully into his spine.

"The project requires unbroken focus," he said. The words sounded rehearsed, empty. Corporate jargon meant for a board of directors, not his wife. "The quantum decoherence window is incredibly narrow. If I leave the containment field unmonitored for even six hours, the entire sequence degrades. Ten years of data, Aditi. Ten years. I can't just walk away to sleep."

"You are losing your mind."

She stepped closer. She was right inside his personal space now. He could smell her—the rainwater, the faint trace of lavender shampoo, and the sour, distinct scent of pure, unadulterated fear.

She reached out and grabbed his left wrist. The same wrist that, minutes ago, had felt crushed by leather and iron.

Arjun flinched violently, ripping his arm away.

Aditi froze, her hand suspended in the empty air between them. Her eyes widened, the hurt registering instantly. It was a physical blow.

"I'm sorry," Arjun gasped, taking another half-step back, rubbing the wrist again. "I'm sorry, I just... my skin hurts. The nerves are over-firing. Too much caffeine."

"Look at me," Aditi whispered.

He didn't want to. He looked at the floor. He looked at the gray grease smudged on the edge of the keyboard. He looked anywhere else.

"Arjun. Look at me."

He forced his eyes up.

A tear broke loose, cutting a clean track through the smeared makeup on her cheek.

"Dr. Rao called me yesterday afternoon," she said, her voice dropping to a fragile, strained pitch. "He said you missed your appointment again. He said you haven't refilled your prescription in two months."

"The pills make me slow," Arjun fired back immediately, defensive, the anger rising to mask the panic. "They dull the receptors. I need to be sharp. The math requires—"

"The math doesn't require you to talk to walls!" She cut him off, her voice vibrating with desperation. "The security guard downstairs, Prakash? He stopped me in the lobby. He asked if you were okay. He said he found you in the parking garage on Tuesday night, kneeling on the concrete, screaming at a car that wasn't there. Screaming in a language he didn't even recognize."

Arjun's stomach dropped. The lab felt suddenly entirely devoid of oxygen.

Tuesday night. The parking garage. He remembered the smell of exhaust. He remembered the blinding flash of headlights. But... no. That wasn't right. It hadn't been a car. It had been a horse. A massive, black warhorse bearing down on him, its hooves striking sparks against cobblestones. He had been screaming orders to a battalion that had died centuries ago.

"I was running calculations out loud," Arjun lied. He lied terribly. The tremor was back in his hand. He gripped the edge of the desk. "Prakash doesn't understand advanced theorem. It sounds like gibberish to him."

"Stop lying to me." Aditi's voice broke completely. She

reached out again, slower this time, and gently placed both her hands flat against his chest. Right over his racing heart. Right over the smear of blood.

Her palms were freezing cold.

"Please," she begged, the word barely a breath. "Arjun. I am begging you. Turn the machine off. Power down the servers. Put your coat on. Let's walk out of this building, get in a cab, and go home. Let me make you a cup of tea. Let's just sleep."

For a moment, he wanted to. God, he wanted to.

He looked down at her hands on his chest. He felt the desperate, frantic rhythm of her pulse matching his own. He pictured their apartment in Bandra. The soft, yellow light of the reading lamp in the corner. The sound of the rain against the bedroom window, safe and distant. The quiet, boring, beautiful predictability of a normal life.

He raised his hands and placed them gently over hers.

"Aditi," he whispered.

But then, the Ananta Device hummed.

It wasn't a mechanical noise. It was a deep, sub-bass vibration that bypassed his ears and resonated directly in his

bone marrow. It was the exact same frequency as the phantom sword striking the shield.

Clang.

Arjun closed his eyes. The lab vanished.

He saw a heavy, curved blade dripping with black liquid. He tasted sour wine heavily laced with poison. He heard a voice—not Aditi's, but someone older, someone terrifyingly regal, speaking through the static in his skull.

You thought you were my savior? You were my prisoner.

His eyes snapped open. The sterile blue light of the lab rushed back in, blinding him.

The data wasn't corrupt. He knew that now, with absolute, terrifying certainty. It wasn't schizophrenia. It wasn't a breakdown. The machine was right. The machine was a key, and it was already turning in the lock.

If he stopped now, the loop would just reset. He would go home, drink the tea, sleep, and eventually, the system would find another way to scrub him out. He would wake up in another century, another life, another cage, completely unaware of the strings attached to his limbs.

He couldn't unsee the strings.

"I can't," Arjun said.

He didn't yell. He didn't sound angry. He just sounded utterly, devastatingly defeated. Aditi froze. She looked up at him, her dark eyes searching his face for a lifeline that wasn't there.

"What do you mean, you can't?" she asked.

Arjun gently removed her freezing hands from his chest. He stepped backward, putting a solid foot of empty space between them. The distance felt like a canyon.

"If I turn it off now, the sequence collapses," Arjun said, turning toward the primary console. The blue light washed over his face, making him look pale, dead. "The noise in my head... Aditi, it's not madness. It's an echo. It's a structural flaw in the timeline. I have to know why I remember dying."

"Arjun, don't."

She lunged forward, grabbing for his arm, grabbing for his shirt, anything to pull him back from the edge.

But he was already moving. He was faster. Driven by an adrenaline spike that tasted like copper and fear.

"I have to see the origin point," he said.

He raised his hand over the activation console. The brass iris of the Ananta Device spun faster, the low hum escalating into a high, whining shriek.

"Arjun, NO!"

Aditi screamed, throwing herself against his back.
He slammed his hand down onto the glass display.

ENTER.

CHAPTER 3



The Saffron & Blood

His hand struck the glass console.

ENTER.

There was no mechanical click. No satisfying tactile feedback. Just the sudden, terrifying realization of a threshold crossed.

For a fraction of a second, absolute silence reigned. The ambient noise of the lab—the gentle whirl of the cooling units, the distant thrum of the Mumbai monsoon—ceased to exist.

Then, the servers screamed.

It wasn't a hum. It was a violent, high-pitched mechanical

shriek that bypassed the eardrums and vibrated directly against the molars. The sound was a physical thing. A solid wall of acoustic pressure that slammed into Arjun's chest, completely knocking the breath out of him.

Aditi's hands, which had been clutching the back of his shirt, were violently ripped away. She was thrown backward by the sheer force of the auditory shockwave, her boots skidding across the polished obsidian floor.

"Arjun!" she shrieked. Or at least, her mouth formed his name. The sound was instantly swallowed by the roar.

At the center of the room, the Ananta Device woke up.

The heavy brass gears ground against each other with a terrifying, industrial friction. The massive central iris, polished chrome and heavy metal, began to dilate. It spun. Faster. Pushing past its safe operational limits, the metal blurring into a continuous, vibrating ring.

The clinical, eighteen-degree blue light of the laboratory disappeared.

It exploded into a blinding, absolute white.

Arjun threw his hands over his eyes, stumbling away from the console. The light burned through his eyelids. It felt hot on his skin, like sitting too close to a magnesium fire.

The floor beneath his feet began to vibrate. Not the subtle tremor of heavy machinery, but a deep, tectonic groan.

He reached out blindly. "Aditi!" he choked out, the air in his lungs feeling thin, stale. "Aditi, get down!"

His fingers found nothing but empty, vibrating air.

Then, the world shifted.

It was a violent, sickening dislocation of reality. The white light didn't simply fade away; it curdled. It thickened, taking on a heavy, suffocating texture. The sterile brightness twisted, bleeding rapidly into a deep, aggressive, blood-soaked saffron.

The temperature in the lab skyrocketed in an instant.

The cool, filtered oxygen vanished. Arjun gasped, his throat instantly parched. A wave of baking, oppressive heat hit him so hard his knees buckled. Sweat erupted across his forehead, stinging his eyes. The familiar, comforting smell of burnt ozone and cold coffee was gone.

It was replaced by an aggressive, nauseating stench. Dry, baking dirt. The sharp, acrid bite of sulphur. And beneath it all, the heavy, sweet rot of dead flowers.

Arjun forced his eyes open, squinting through the saffron haze.

The reinforced glass walls of the Verma Institute—two inches of bulletproof polymer designed to withstand a hurricane—were melting. They peeled away exactly like burning film caught in a hot projector. The glass bubbled, blackened, and disintegrated into ash.

Beyond the melting glass, the gray, rain-drenched skyline of Mumbai was entirely gone.

There was no city. There was no sea link. There was no rain.

There was only a vast, endless expanse of packed dirt, baking under a merciless, furious sun. It was a battlefield. The air was thick with ash and the distant, chaotic roar of men and beasts.

Arjun staggered, his leather shoes slipping. But they weren't slipping on smooth obsidian anymore. They were finding no purchase in loose, dry sand.

"What..." he rasped, coughing as the sulfur filled his lungs. "What is..."

And then, the pain hit.

Arjun screamed.

It tore out of his throat—a guttural, unthinking roar of a dying animal. A sudden, jagged line of pure, searing agony ripped diagonally across his chest. It felt as though a hot iron had been dragged forcefully through his ribs.

He looked down, his vision swimming.

His pristine white lab coat tore completely open, the thick cotton parting effortlessly as if sliced by an invisible razor. Beneath it, his shirt split.

Wet redness bloomed rapidly across the torn fabric, a hot, sticky stain spreading outward with terrifying speed. The pain was incredibly specific. It wasn't a vague ache. It was the distinct, unmistakable feeling of a heavy, curved steel blade carving directly through his muscle and scraping against his sternum.

His legs gave out entirely.

He crashed heavily to his knees in the hot dirt, his hands flying to his chest to clutch the phantom wound. Real, hot blood seeped thickly between his trembling fingers, coating his palms.

"Arjun!"

The voice was faint. Frantic.

"Stop it! Turn it off!" Aditi screamed.

Arjun twisted his body, gritting his teeth against the searing fire in his chest. He looked for her.

Aditi was standing ten feet away, but she didn't belong here. Her trench coat was still dripping with Mumbai rain, but the drops evaporated before they hit the baking sand. Her outline was flickering. Her voice was already fading, being actively dragged away by the hot, dry wind of a completely different century.

She was becoming translucent. A glitching, desperate ghost from the future, trapped inside a rapidly materializing past.

"Aditi," Arjun choked. He tried to reach a bloody hand out toward her. "Run. Just... get out."

She reached back, her mouth open in a silent scream. But her hand passed entirely through the saffron air, dissolving into a fine mist of static.

"You were never meant to wake up."

The whisper did not come from the battlefield. It didn't belong to the roar of the wind or the hum of the failing servers. It cut through the sheer noise of the chaos like a cold, sharp knife. It was perfectly calm. Imperial.

Arjun dropped his hand. He looked up, gasping for air, his chest heaving.

Standing directly in the center of the saffron storm, entirely untouched by the howling wind and the heat, was a woman.

She did not wear a lab coat. She wore sweeping, ancient robes that seemed to be woven directly from dark smoke and shifting starlight. The fabric did not ripple in the wind; it moved with its own slow, deliberate gravity. Her face was ageless, carved from perfect, unyielding calm. But her eyes...

Her eyes held an expression of profound, terrifying sorrow.

The Oracle looked down at the bleeding, kneeling physicist. The pity in her stare terrified him far more than the agonizing pain radiating from his chest.

"I—" Arjun coughed, a wet splatter of dark blood hitting the sand. "I saw... I remember."

"The glitch is being corrected," she said.

She didn't speak the words. Her mouth remained perfectly still. The voice simply resonated directly inside the bone of his skull, echoing in the space behind his eyes.

Arjun ground his teeth. He tried to crawl. He dug his bloody fingers into the coarse sand, trying to drag his body back toward where the console used to be, desperate to reverse the sequence. But his limbs felt incredibly heavy, as if his muscles were rapidly turning to cold stone.

The floor beneath him—the last few polished obsidian tiles of the Verma Institute—finally dissolved completely into the dirt. The lab was gone. The present was gone.

"Who..." Arjun wheezed. Blood bubbled hot and metallic on his lips. He fought to keep his eyes open. "Who... are... you?"

The woman did not move toward him. She simply watched him bleed.

"I am the ending," The Oracle replied.

She raised a single hand. Her palm began to glow with a soft, blinding white light.

The heat stopped. The pain in his chest went entirely numb. The howling wind of the battlefield ceased.

The world began to break. The remaining images of the lab, the fading silhouette of Aditi, the falling rain, the Ananta Device—it all shattered. The environment fractured into

billions of tiny, perfect shards of light, spinning rapidly away into an endless, suffocating void.

The darkness rushed in, cold and absolute.

"Sleep, Arjun," the voice echoed in his fading mind.

CHAPTER 4



The Dead Space

Arjun did not land; he floated.

The transition was violent in its absolute lack of violence. One moment, he was kneeling in the baking dirt of a fractured century, his chest ripped open, choking on his own hot blood and the heavy stench of sulfur. He was screaming. His lungs were burning.

And then, nothing.

The lab was gone. The battlefield was gone. The searing, agonizing pain carving through his sternum vanished so completely that its absence left a strange, hollow ache. The terrifying calm of The Oracle and the fading, desperate silhouette of Aditi dissolved into the dark.

It was a suffocating darkness. It wasn't the airy, empty

black of a night sky. It was thick. Viscous. It pressed against him with the heavy, unyielding pressure of crude oil. It filled the spaces where his eyes should be, where his lungs should be.

He tried to gasp, to pull in a frantic breath of air, but there was no air. There was no chest to expand. He tried to thrash, to kick his legs and fight his way up to the surface, but he had no legs. He tried to scream Aditi's name, to tear his vocal cords raw, but he had no mouth.

He was stripped down to the barest, rawest filament of existence. He was just a consciousness. A rogue, unmoored signal adrift in the vast, dead space between radio stations.

Panic, pure and formless, spiked in the void. *Am I dead? Is this it? Is this the zero state?*

He waited for the final fade. He waited for the brain activity to cease, for the scattered electrical impulses to finally quiet down into nothingness.

Instead, the Dreams came. They didn't start gently. They didn't feel like a reel of movie film playing on a distant screen. They were a physical assault. They felt entirely invasive, violent, tearing their way into a skull that was fundamentally too small to hold them. It was the sensation of a hard drive being forcibly overwritten, sector by sector, with data that was heavy, jagged, and actively bleeding.

Taste hit him first.

Sharp. Metallic. Copper mixing with the thick, sour tang of spoiled wine. His throat burned with it. It wasn't a memory of a taste; it was happening *now*.

He was suddenly on his knees, not in the lab, not in the void, but on a floor of smooth, cold marble. His hand—a large, calloused hand bearing thick scars that were not his own—was tightly clutching a heavy goblet of solid gold. The metal was freezing against his fevered, sweating skin. He could feel the intricate, raised carvings on the gold pressing painfully into his palm.

His stomach cramped violently, rejecting the poison in the wine. He doubled over, gasping, coughing up a wet, dark splatter onto the marble.

Sight returned.

A woman's face swam into focus through the dim, flickering light of oil lamps.

She was beautiful. Terrifyingly so. Her dark, piercing eyes were heavily lined with thick kohl. She wore robes the color of a bruised sunset. But there was no warmth in her gaze. There was only a cold, ancient, hollow deadness. It was a face built entirely of betrayal.

"You thought you were my savior?" her voice echoed.

It didn't sound human. It was distorted, booming from everywhere and nowhere all at once, layering over itself with a synthetic, metallic rasp.

"You were my prisoner," the voice boomed, rattling the cold marble beneath his knees.

Arjun recoiled. Or, the man holding the goblet recoiled. The boundary between them was failing. Arjun felt the heartbreak hit him directly in the chest.

It was massive. Devastating. But it wasn't his heartbreak. It wasn't the sharp, frantic panic of losing Aditi. This was something else. A grief so incredibly ancient, so deeply entrenched, that it felt like it had been gathering thick dust for centuries. It was the grief of a loyal soldier realizing his entire existence, his every drop of spilled blood, had been a calculated lie.

It was a heavy, suffocating weight pressing down on him in the void, threatening to crush his fragile consciousness completely. He was drowning in another man's sorrow.

No. Stop. I am Arjun. I am Dr. Arjun Verma.

"WAKE UP." The new voice hit the void like a physical

blow.

It didn't belong to the Queen. It wasn't layered, cold, or synthetic. It was male. Extremely rough. Entirely desperate.

It cut straight through the suffocating dream, a jagged, ugly frequency tearing through the velvet darkness.

"LISTEN... TO... ME..."

The pitch-black oil of the void around Arjun suddenly began to crackle. White noise. Hissing, popping static. It was loud. Deafening. It sounded exactly like an old, broken analog radio frantically trying to find a clear signal in the middle of a violent electrical storm.

The static scraped against his mind, pushing back the sour taste of the wine, blurring the edges of the Queen's kohl-rimmed eyes.

"DO... NOT... TRUST... THE... RAIN..."

The words formed painfully out of the chaos, broken and stuttering.

Arjun thrashed wildly in the dark, fighting against the thick pressure.

Who are you? he screamed silently into the black. Where

am I? What is this?

The hissing spiked, the white noise flaring bright in his nonexistent eyes. The connection stabilized for a fraction of a second. The voice roared back, much clearer now, vibrating with absolute urgency and a deep, burning anger.

"I AM THE GHOST," the rough voice commanded, the sound of a man who had fought a thousand wars.

"WAKE UP, ARJUN. THEY ARE COMING FOR YOU."

A sharp, high-frequency whine pierced the void.

The darkness cracked.

A jagged, blinding fissure of gray light split the oil-slick blackness directly down the middle.

The silence shattered completely.

CHAPTER 5



Auto-Correct

The ceiling fan turned. A slow, lazy rotation. *Thwump.*
Thwump. Thwump.

Aditi stared at it. The plaster above the blades was cracked, a jagged little fault line she had been meaning to paint over since they moved in. It looked different today. Shallower.

She blinked. The air in the bedroom was heavy, dragging into her lungs with a stale, metallic weight. Her mouth tasted like old pennies and sleep. She swallowed, the dry click loud in the quiet room.

How did I get here?

She pushed herself up onto her elbows. The cotton sheets twisted around her legs, heavy and damp with cold

sweat. She was wearing an oversized gray t-shirt. She ran a hand over the fabric. It was completely dry.

Yesterday—or maybe it was hours ago, the timeline in her head felt like a tangled spool of wire—she had been in the lab. She remembered the blinding white light. She remembered the heat baking her skin. She remembered the distinct, nauseating stench of sulfur and the sight of Arjun kneeling in the dirt, his chest torn open, bleeding out on a sand floor that shouldn't have existed.

And the woman. The woman woven from smoke.

Aditi swung her legs over the edge of the mattress. Her bare feet hit the cold hardwood.

"Arjun?"

The word dropped into the apartment and died. No echo. No answering shuffle of slippers from the kitchen.

She stood up. A sharp, localized spike of pain hammered directly behind her right eye. She swayed, catching the edge of the heavy wooden dresser to steady herself. The wood was cold under her palm.

"Arjun, are you..." She trailed off.

The apartment was too quiet. It lacked the low-frequency

hum of his existence. There was no hiss of the espresso machine. No muttered curses over a misplaced stylus. Just the oppressive *thwump* of the ceiling fan pushing dead air around.

She walked out into the narrow hallway. The floorboards, usually prone to groaning under the slightest weight, were perfectly silent beneath her steps.

She stopped at the bathroom door. She pushed it open. The fluorescent strip above the mirror flickered once, then buzzed a steady, irritating pitch. She looked at the porcelain cup sitting on the edge of the sink.

It held one toothbrush. Blue. Hers.

She stared at it. The ceramic cup had a faint, circular ring of dried calcium at the bottom, wide enough to accommodate two handles. But the yellow toothbrush was gone.

Not misplaced. Not fallen behind the toilet. Gone.

A cold, crawling sensation started at the base of her neck. It wasn't the rational fear of an intruder. It was something far worse. It was the deep, primal instinct of an animal noticing a sudden drop in barometric pressure.

She left the bathroom. She walked into the kitchen.

The morning light filtering through the blinds was flat and gray, casting long, bruised shadows across the granite countertops. The espresso machine sat in the corner. She walked over to it and pressed her thumb against the warming plate on top. Cold. Stone cold.

She looked at the mug rack mounted on the wall. Four mugs hung from small brass hooks. The fifth hook—the one meant for his chipped, oversized university mug—was empty.

Aditi reached out and dragged her index finger across the empty hook.

Dust. A thick, gray smudge of it coated her fingertip.

"No," she whispered.

She rubbed the dust between her thumb and forefinger. It was gritty. It took months for dust to settle like that.

Panic finally broke through the groggy haze of sleep. It was a hot, sharp rush of adrenaline that made her fingers tremble. She turned around, her eyes scanning the living room.

The low bookshelf near the window. The bottom two shelves were dedicated entirely to his heavy, dense quantum

mechanics textbooks.

She walked over. The shelves were packed tightly with her own novels. Fiction. Poetry. Biographies. Not a single spine bore the logo of the Verma Institute.

She looked up at the mantelpiece.

A silver frame sat squarely in the center. She knew the photo. Goa, three years ago. The monsoon retreat. They were standing on the balcony of the rental, laughing, his arm wrapped tight around her waist to block the wind.

She picked the frame up. The silver metal was icy.

She stared at the photograph behind the glass.

It was Goa. It was the balcony. The gray, churning ocean was in the background. But Arjun wasn't there.

It was just Aditi. She was standing alone, leaning slightly against the railing, offering a tight, polite smile to whoever was holding the camera. Her right arm hung uselessly at her side, exactly where his waist should have been.

"No. No, no, no."

She dropped the frame. It hit the hardwood floor with a sharp crack, the glass spider-webbing across her solo,

smiling face.

She didn't look down. She sprinted toward the kitchen island, her bare feet slapping hard against the floor. Her phone was sitting perfectly aligned with the edge of the marble, plugged into its white charging cable.

She snatched it up, ripping the cord from the port. Her hands shook violently. She unlocked the screen. The brightness seared her eyes. She opened her contacts and tapped the search bar.

A-R-J-U-N.

No Results.

She deleted it. Typed it again, faster, her thumbs slipping on the glass.

A-R-J-U-N V-E-R-M-A.

No Results.

Her breath hitched, coming in shallow, ragged pulls. "Okay. Okay. A glitch. A phone glitch."

She backed out of the app. She opened the dialer. She knew his number. Ten digits. Carved into her brain over ten years. She tapped them in, her fingernails clicking sharply

against the screen, and pressed the green call button. She pressed the phone hard against her ear.

Silence. A low hiss of static.

Then, a perfectly modulated, synthetic female voice.

"The number you have dialed is unassigned. Please check the number and try again."

Aditi lowered the phone. She stared at the black screen. Her reflection stared back. She looked terrified. She looked insane.

Call the lab. Call the Institute. She raised the phone again. She didn't know the front desk number by heart. She searched for Dr. Rao. The institute's head of psychological evaluation. He had been seeing Arjun for the past six months. He would know. He would explain the lab explosion. He would tell her Arjun was in the medical wing.

She found the contact. *Rao, Clinic.* She pressed call.

It rang. Once. Twice. The sound was deafening in the silent kitchen.

"Hello?" The voice on the other end was thick with sleep, accompanied by the rustle of bedsheets. "Aditi?"

"Doctor Rao." Her voice cracked on his name. She

squeezed her eyes shut. "I'm sorry. I know it's... I don't even know what time it is. But I need..." She swallowed hard, trying to force the panic down. "I need you to tell me where he is."

A pause on the line. A long, heavy hesitation. She heard a soft click—a bedside lamp turning on.

"Where who is, Aditi?" Dr. Rao asked. His voice had shifted. The sleepiness vanished, instantly replaced by a careful, measured caution. It was the voice of a professional walking on thin ice.

"Arjun," she said. The name felt heavy on her tongue. "He was at the lab. We were at the lab. The machine, it... it went critical. There was a flash. I don't remember how I got home. Is he at the hospital? Did security find us?"

Another pause. The silence stretched so tight it felt like it might snap and take her head off.

"Aditi," Dr. Rao said softly. A sigh dragged through the phone speaker. "Did you stop taking the lithium?"

She froze. The kitchen seemed to tilt a few degrees to the left.

"What?"

"The medication, Aditi. We talked about this last week. The grief can manifest in extremely vivid auditory and visual hallucinations if you disrupt the chemical balance."

"I don't take lithium," she snapped, stepping away from the island, her voice rising. "I don't—Dr. Rao, I am asking about my husband. I am asking about Dr. Arjun Verma. The lead physicist at your institute."

"Aditi. Stop." It was a command. Firm. Gentle. Utterly devastating. "Breathe. Count to three."

"I am not going to count to three!"

"Arjun has been gone for three years," Dr. Rao said. He didn't rush the words. He laid them out slowly, carefully, as if placing heavy stones on her chest. "The car crash on the Sea Link. It was raining. The tires lost grip. Aditi, you delivered the eulogy. We have been working through this trauma for thirty-six months."

"No." She shook her head rapidly, backing up until her shoulder blades hit the refrigerator door. The metal was cold through her t-shirt. "No. I was with him last night. He was wearing a white shirt. He had a scratch on his jaw. He was bleeding."

"That is a memory misfiring," Dr. Rao insisted, his tone dripping with a clinical pity that made her stomach churn.

"Your brain is attempting to construct a narrative to avoid the anniversary of the accident. It's next week. This is a common regression. I want you to go to the bathroom cabinet. Check the orange bottle."

"He was in the lab," Aditi whispered. Her eyes darted wildly around the empty kitchen. The dust on the hook. The single toothbrush.

Reality was overwriting itself. It wasn't just erasing him; it was actively building a completely new architecture to fill the void. It was patching the code.

"Aditi, I am going to drive over," Dr. Rao said. "Stay on the phone with me. Go sit on the couch."

She hung up.

She threw the phone onto the granite counter. It clattered and slid to a stop.

She pressed her palms against the side of her head, digging her fingers into her scalp. Her breathing was entirely out of control, short, violent gasps that provided no oxygen. The apartment felt like a simulation, a cheap film set where someone had forgotten to place half the props.

I delivered the eulogy. Three years. Was she crazy? Was it a psychotic break?

She pushed away from the refrigerator. She ran down the hallway, her bare feet slipping on the wood. She threw open the door to the small coat closet near the entryway.

The hangers clattered violently against the wooden rod. She shoved her winter coats aside, clawing through the fabric.

There.

Pushed all the way to the back, crushed against the drywall, was the trench coat she had worn last night.

She grabbed it, yanking it off the plastic hanger. It fell into her arms in a heavy, stiff heap.

She ran her hands over the fabric. It was entirely bone dry. Not a single drop of Mumbai rainwater clung to the material. No dampness at the hem.

"No," she sobbed, sinking to her knees right there in the entryway, clutching the coat to her chest. She buried her face in the thick collar. "Please, no."

She squeezed her eyes shut, ready to surrender. Ready to accept that her mind had finally broken under the weight of a grief she didn't even remember earning.

But then she inhaled.

She pulled a heavy, shaking breath through the fabric of the coat.

She stopped crying.

She opened her eyes, pulling the collar away from her face. She brought it back to her nose and sniffed again, slow and deep.

It didn't smell like the cedar blocks in the closet. It didn't smell like her lavender perfume.

It smelled distinctly, undeniably, of burnt ozone.

She ran her hands frantically down the length of the coat, flipping it over, checking the lining, checking the pockets. Her fingers snagged on something near the bottom left hem.

She held the fabric up to the gray morning light.

There, near the seam, was a hole. It was small, roughly the size of a coin. The edges of the fabric weren't torn or frayed. They were blackened, stiff, and melted. It was a burn mark. A fresh, chemical scorch.

And buried deep within the melted fibers, so faint she almost missed it, was the microscopic, sharp, and impossible scent of baking sulfur.

The system was fast. It had scrubbed his books, his coffee mug, his toothbrush. It had rewritten a doctor's memory and planted a silver photo frame to secure the lie.

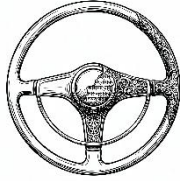
But it wasn't perfect. It had missed a spot.

Aditi sat on the hardwood floor, staring at the tiny scorched hole in her coat. Her hands stopped trembling. The panic slowly drained out of her, leaving behind a cold, sharp, terrifying clarity.

She wasn't crazy. She was being erased.

**ACT II:
BLEEDING
TIMELINES**

CHAPTER 6



1965

The silence of the void did not fade; it snapped.

Sound rushed back in a violent, physical wave that felt like a blow to the side of the head. It wasn't the sterile, pressurized hum of the Verma Institute. It was a chaotic, deafening roar.

Thunder cracked, low and bowel-shaking, vibrating directly up through the soles of his shoes. The rhythmic, relentless hammering of heavy rain beat against a thin metal roof just inches above his skull. Beneath the rain, there was a deep, rhythmic crashing—tons of black water smashing violently against a stone seawall.

Arjun gasped, his eyes flying open.

His lungs expanded, pulling in air that tasted nothing like the filtered ozone of the 2026 lab. The air was thick, hot,

and choked with the heavy, nauseating stench of stale tobacco, wet leather, and raw, unburned gasoline.

He wasn't floating. He was sitting.

He gripped the edge of something solid in front of him. His fingers dug desperately into a surface that felt slightly sticky in the humid air. He looked down. His hands were braced hard against a dashboard made of cheap, deeply cracked vinyl. The entire console was vibrating with a rough, uneven purr that rattled his teeth. It was an engine. An old, poorly tuned engine idling rough.

He was in a car.

Arjun squeezed his eyes shut, pressing his head back against the seatrest. The material felt rough and damp. He tried to slow his breathing. *One. Two. Three.* He focused on his chest. He expected his hands to come away slick with the hot, wet blood from the Mughal sword strike. He expected his sternum to be split open.

He touched his chest.

There was no hole. No blood. But deep beneath the skin, the phantom scar from the blade throbbed with a dull, tender heat, exactly like a fresh, deep-tissue bruise.

His fingers didn't find the smooth, torn cotton of a lab

coat. They brushed against thick, heavy, itchy wool. A suit jacket. The collar of a stiff shirt dug uncomfortably into his neck. A thin tie was knotted tightly at his throat, suffocating him. He pulled at the knot, his fingers clumsy and numb, loosening it until he could pull in a full breath.

He opened his eyes and looked out the windshield.

The glass was streaked and blurred by the deluge, the heavy wipers dragging across the pane with a rhythmic, failing squeak. Beyond the glass, the world was a murky, drowned blur of gray water and deep, shifting shadows. He couldn't see the sleek, neon-lit skyline of modern Mumbai. He saw the skeletal, rusting silhouettes of massive cargo cranes looming in the dark, and the hulking, mountainous shapes of docked cargo ships.

A sickly, pale yellow glow from a row of sodium streetlamps struggled to cut through the downpour, casting long, distorted shadows across the wet cobblestones.

Where am I? "You okay, boss?"

The voice came from his right. It was close. Casual.

Arjun froze. His heart kicked against his ribs, a hard, frantic thump. He turned his head slowly. The muscles in his neck felt incredibly stiff, as if he had been sleeping in an awkward position for days.

Sitting in the driver's seat was Vikram.

Arjun opened his mouth to speak, but the name caught in his dry throat. He stared.

It was Vikram. The facial structure, the slope of the nose, the line of the jaw—it was undeniably his eager, spectacled graduate student. The kid who brought him overpriced lattes, double-checked his quantum equations, and nervously apologized whenever he bumped a desk.

But this wasn't that Vikram.

This man wore a sharp, charcoal-gray suit that looked heavy with humidity and wear. The thick, black-rimmed glasses were gone. His hair wasn't an unruly mop; it was slicked aggressively back with pomade, glistening wetly in the faint, yellow dashboard lights.

And there was a distinct, heavy bulge pushing out the fabric under his left armpit. A leather shoulder holster.

Click. Whoosh. Vikram held a silver Zippo lighter to a cigarette clamped between his lips. The sudden flare of orange flame sharply illuminated his face.

It was harder. Older. The eager innocence of the twenty-something grad student had been entirely hollowed out,

replaced by a cynical, bone-deep weariness. Deep lines bracketed his mouth. His eyes were flat, completely deadened to whatever it was they were doing out here in the dark.

Vikram snapped the Zippo shut. The metallic *clack* was incredibly loud in the confined space of the car. He took a long, slow drag, the cherry of the cigarette flaring bright red, and blew a thick stream of gray smoke directly against the fogged windshield.

"You were murmuring in your sleep again," Vikram said. His voice lacked the nervous pitch Arjun was used to. It was a gravelly baritone, roughened by years of cheap tobacco.

"I..." Arjun started, then stopped. He coughed as the secondhand smoke hit the back of his throat. He covered his mouth with the back of his hand. His knuckles were unscarred. Smooth. "I was?"

"Yeah." Vikram rolled his window down a crack. The roar of the ocean and the hiss of the rain instantly invaded the cabin, bringing a blast of cold, salty air. "Something about a Queen?"

Arjun's stomach dropped. *Queen Mebrunissa. The poison. The static.* The voice from the void—Rishi Malhotra's desperate, angry roar—suddenly echoed in the back of his skull, so loud he thought Vikram must have heard it.

Do not trust the rain.

Arjun looked out the side window at the flooded docks. He looked back at Vikram. He had to play this carefully. The simulation—if that's what this terrifying, physical reality was—had dropped him into an avatar. A role. And Vikram wasn't his friend here. Vikram was something else.

"Just... a dream," Arjun managed, rubbing his eyes. He forced his hand down, resting it on his wool-clad thigh to hide the tremor. "Bad sleep. My head is killing me."

"Don't tell me the whiskey's got your memory already," Vikram muttered, taking another drag. He tapped the ash out the cracked window into the storm. "You drank half a bottle of imported scotch at the club. Told you to pace it."

Whiskey. A club. Arjun cataloged the information, building the lie in real-time.

"Right," Arjun said, keeping his tone flat, noncommittal. He shifted in the seat. The springs of the old Ambassador groaned beneath his weight. He looked at the dashboard. There was an analog clock, the hands glowing faintly green. 11:42 PM. Next to it, a small, flip-page calendar was glued to the vinyl.

The numbers were too small to read in the dim light.

He needed to know. He needed an anchor.

"Vik," Arjun said. He swallowed hard. The name felt strange. "What year is it?"

Vikram stopped smoking. He turned his head slowly, looking at Arjun. For a long, terrible second, the only sound was the heavy thrum of the engine and the wipers scraping the glass. Vikram's dead eyes narrowed, searching Arjun's face for a punchline.

Then, Vikram laughed.

It was a dry, humorless sound. It sounded like dry autumn leaves being crushed under a boot.

"Very funny," Vikram said. But he didn't look amused. He reached out with a nicotine-stained index finger and tapped the small dashboard calendar.

Arjun leaned closer, squinting through the gloom.

The bold, black ink on the yellowed paper read: *August 1965.*

Arjun fell back against the seat. The breath left his lungs in a silent rush. Sixty-one years. He had jumped backward more than six decades from the lab in Mumbai. But he had

just been in the Mughal era, four hundred years in the past.

The timeline wasn't just broken. It was bleeding out.

"1965," Arjun whispered. The words tasted like ash.

"Yeah, 1965, Arjun," Vikram said, his tone shifting from casual to slightly irritated. He tossed the half-smoked cigarette out the window and rolled the glass up, sealing out the worst of the storm. "We have a job to do. Snap out of it."

"A job," Arjun repeated. He looked at his own hands again. They weren't holding a sword, and they weren't typing quantum physics equations. They were resting on the knees of a charcoal suit.

Vikram reached over into the shadowy back seat of the car. Leather groaned. He pulled something forward and tossed it casually onto Arjun's lap.

It landed with a dull *smack* against his thighs.

It was a thick manila folder. The edges were slightly frayed and damp from the humidity.

"Kaal Nath wants this closed tonight," Vikram said, shifting the car out of park. The heavy transmission clunked loudly. "No loose ends."

Kaal Nath.

The name hit Arjun's brain like a physical blow. A sharp, violent spike of pain drove directly behind his right eye, an ice pick driven straight into his frontal lobe. He winced, sucking air through his teeth.

He remembered the courtyard of the Red Fort. He remembered the static. *The Enforcer*. "Who?" Arjun asked, his voice barely a breath.

Vikram paused, his hand resting heavily on the gearshift. He looked at Arjun again, and this time, the irritation was gone. It was replaced by a cold, calculating assessment.

"The boss, Arjun," Vikram said slowly, enunciating every word. "The man who pays us to clean up the messes. The man who is going to be very unhappy if we sit in this car playing amnesia games instead of finishing the hit."

Arjun stared at the manila folder sitting on his lap. It felt impossibly heavy.

"Right," Arjun said. He dragged a hand through his hair. It was dry, slicked down with something heavy and oily. Not his hair. Not his life. "Just... give me a second. I'm shaking it off."

"Take your time," Vikram said, though his tone suggested otherwise. He pulled a fresh cigarette from a crumpled pack in his breast pocket. "But we move in five. Check the target."

Arjun looked down at the frayed edges of the folder. The rain hammered against the roof, a deafening drumbeat that completely drowned out the silence of the void he had just escaped.

He placed his smooth, unscarred hand on the thick paper cover, feeling the cold dampness of the material. He didn't want to open it. He didn't want to see what a 1965 hitman considered a "loose end." But he had to play the role. He had to survive the glitch.

Slowly, his fingers trembling, Arjun flipped the folder open.

CHAPTER 7



The Hit

The manila folder felt damp. It was soft, the cheap paper warping slightly from the heavy humidity trapped inside the Ambassador.

Arjun peeled the cover back. The hinge of the cardboard creaked.

Inside, there was a single sheet of typed paper. A rusty paperclip bit into the top left corner, fastening a black-and-white photograph to the document. The text underneath was a blur of bureaucratic Hindi and English, heavily redacted with thick, black marker. But Arjun wasn't looking at the text.

He was staring at the photograph.

His brain simply stopped processing. It hit a hard,

insurmountable wall of cognitive dissonance. The heavy drumming of the rain on the car roof seemed to fade away, replaced by the rushing, rushing sound of his own blood in his ears.

The photograph was grainy. High contrast. The harsh flash flattened the depth of the room. But the details were undeniable.

The man in the center of the frame wasn't wearing a 1965 charcoal suit. He was wearing a pristine, white laboratory coat. His hair was cut short, styled differently. He was standing in a vast room filled with impossible machinery, bathed in a light that translated to stark white on the vintage film but that Arjun knew, down in his bones, was a clinical, eighteen-degree blue. Hovering in the air behind the man were translucent holographic screens, glowing with complex quantum equations.

And behind the man, dominating the background, was a massive, rotating brass iris. The Ananta Device.

Arjun dragged his thumb across the glossy surface of the photo. He touched the face of the man.

It was him.

He looked down at the bottom right corner of the photograph. Stamped in rigid, mechanical red ink was a

date.

OCTOBER 14, 2026.

Sixty-one years in the future.

A hot, sour wave of nausea hit the back of his throat. He swallowed hard, his Adam's apple bobbing painfully against the tight knot of his tie.

"This..." Arjun started. His voice shook so badly the word barely formed. He tapped his finger against the photo, his hand trembling uncontrollably. He looked up at Vikram. "This is me."

Vikram didn't look at the folder. He didn't look at the road. He had stopped smoking.

"But this..." Arjun gasped, his chest tightening. The air in the car was suddenly entirely gone. "This isn't possible. The date. The machine."

"It's a glitch," Vikram said. His voice was incredibly soft. Too soft.

The tone made Arjun freeze.

It wasn't the annoyed, gravelly bark of the hitman who had just tossed him the file. It was something else entirely.

It was the precise, terrifyingly calm tone of a surgeon delivering a terminal diagnosis.

Arjun looked at him.

The Zippo lighter was gone. The cigarette was gone. Vikram's right hand was resting casually on his thigh, but the fingers were curled loosely around the grips of a heavy, matte-black revolver. The metal of the barrel caught the sickly yellow glare of the distant streetlamps. It was pointed directly at Arjun's ribs.

Vikram's eyes were dead. Not weary. Not cynical. Dead. There was no hesitation in them. Just a terrible, crushing weight of professional duty mixed with a microscopic sliver of pity.

"A mistake in the pattern," Vikram clarified. He slowly lifted the gun, leveling the dark, hollow eye of the barrel squarely at Arjun's chest.

Arjun pressed his spine hard against the passenger door, his boots pushing against the floorboards. The cracked vinyl squeaked beneath him. His heart hammered against his ribs like a trapped bird, a frantic, vibrating panic.

"Vikram," Arjun breathed, his hands coming up, palms open. The folder slid off his lap, spilling onto the dirty floor mat. "What are you doing? It's me."

"I know it's you, brother," Vikram whispered. "That's the tragedy of it."

Click. Vikram's thumb pulled the hammer back. The sharp, mechanical sound was incredibly loud. It was louder than the thunder rolling across the Bombay docks. It was the sound of a period being placed at the end of a very short sentence.

"You weren't supposed to see that photo, Arjun," Vikram said, his voice dropping into a flat, almost robotic cadence. He tilted his head slightly, studying Arjun like a broken line of code. "You weren't supposed to remember the lab. You were supposed to play your part, catch the bad guy, and start the loop again."

Arjun stared at the gun. He could see the dull lead of the bullets sitting in the cylinder.

"The loop?" Arjun repeated, his mind scrambling, slipping on the wet floor of this impossible reality. "Vik, listen to yourself. Put the gun down. We can figure this out."

"The Oracle says you're corrupted," Vikram continued, ignoring him entirely. He leaned a fraction of an inch closer. "Says the file has to be wiped before it spreads."

The Oracle.

The name triggered a flash of the saffron storm. The woman made of smoke. *I am the ending*. Vikram wasn't a friend. He wasn't even a 1965 mobster. He was an immune system response. A white blood cell dispatched to eradicate an infection.

"Don't take it personally," Vikram whispered, his finger tightening on the trigger.

"RUN."

The voice in Arjun's skull roared. It was Rishi Malhotra. The static flared so violently it caused a sharp spike of physical pain behind Arjun's eyes, vibrating his jawbone.

Arjun didn't think. The physics of the moment took over.

His eyes darted to the dashboard. Sitting near the center console, wedged into a cheap wire cup holder, was the Styrofoam cup of coffee Vikram had bought at a stall ten minutes ago. Thin tendrils of steam were still curling out of the plastic lid.

Arjun lunged.

His left hand shot out, his fingers wrapping around the hot, yielding foam. He didn't pull it toward himself. In one violent, unbroken motion, he ripped the cup from the wire

holder and hurled the steaming black liquid directly across the narrow cabin.

The boiling coffee caught Vikram squarely in the face.

"Aargh!"

Vikram roared, a wet, guttural scream of absolute shock and agony. His head snapped back. He dropped his left hand from the steering wheel, frantically batting at his scalding eyes.

His right hand seized. The finger jerked.

BANG!

The explosion of the .38 caliber in the enclosed space of the Ambassador was deafening. It felt like a physical slap to the eardrums. A flash of blinding yellow muzzle flare illuminated the cabin.

The heavy slug missed Arjun's ribs by half an inch. It tore straight through the windshield. The glass didn't shatter outward; it instantly spiderwebbed into a dense, opaque mosaic of thousands of tiny diamonds, completely blinding the view of the docks.

Arjun's ears rang with a high, sustained shriek. He smelled the sharp, metallic bite of gunpowder mixing with the spilled, burning coffee.

Vikram was thrashing, raising the gun again, firing blindly.

BANG! A bullet punched through the roof panel, tearing a jagged hole in the metal. Rainwater immediately began dripping through the opening.

Arjun twisted his body. He kicked out wildly with his right boot, slamming his heel into the chrome handle of the passenger door. The latch gave way with a sharp *clack*.

The door swung wide open, catching the heavy ocean wind. The storm rushed in, a freezing deluge of seawater and rain.

Arjun threw his weight sideways and tumbled out of the car.

He fell. The drop felt longer than it should have.

He hit the wet pavement hard. The rough, uneven cobblestones and broken asphalt tore instantly through the knees of his charcoal suit. He rolled, his shoulder taking the brunt of the impact, jarring his collarbone so violently he thought he heard it crack.

He skidded to a halt on his stomach, splashing into a shallow puddle slick with oily rainbows.

The taste of rain, salt, and bitter motor oil flooded his mouth. He spat, gasping for air. His ears were still ringing, reducing the storm to a muffled, underwater hum.

"Arjun!"

Vikram screamed from inside the car. It wasn't the cold, dead voice of the Enforcer anymore. It was pure, furious rage. The passenger door creaked as Vikram threw his weight across the seat, trying to get a clear line of sight.

Arjun scrambled. His hands slipped on the greasy stones. The wool of his suit was instantly soaked, dragging him down with five extra pounds of freezing weight. He pushed himself up onto his hands and knees, ignoring the stinging scrapes on his palms.

He didn't look back.

He staggered to his feet, his right leg protesting, a sharp pain shooting up his calf. He ignored it.

"DO NOT STOP," the heavy, static-laced voice of Rishi commanded in his head, cutting through the ringing. "FIND THE WALL."

Arjun threw himself forward. He sprinted away from the idling Ambassador, diving straight into the dark, towering maze of rusted shipping containers that lined the Bombay

docks. The shadows swallowed him.

Behind him, another gunshot cracked through the storm. A bullet ricocheted off a steel container a few feet to his left, throwing a shower of bright orange sparks into the rain.

He ran into the drowning night, the rain aggressively washing away the world he had just been standing in.

CHAPTER 8



The Echoes

He ran.

His boots slammed hard against the slick, uneven cobblestones of the 1965 Bombay docks. Every footfall sent a sharp, jarring ache up his shins. The rain wasn't falling; it was driving horizontally, a freezing, physical assault that blinded him and choked the air out of his throat.

Arjun took a sharp right, skidding wildly. His leather soles found zero traction on the oil-slicked stones. He slammed his right shoulder hard against the corrugated steel wall of a massive red shipping container. The impact rattled his teeth. A localized explosion of dull pain flared in his rotator cuff. He bounced off the metal, stumbling forward into a narrow, suffocating alleyway formed by two towering stacks of rusted crates.

His lungs burned. They screamed for oxygen. The heavy, soaked wool of the charcoal suit felt exactly like a wet cast, dragging him down, restricting the expansion of his chest.

He stopped. He pressed his back flat against the freezing, wet steel of a container.

He squeezed his eyes shut, pressing the heels of his hands against his forehead. The cold smudge of sweat and rainwater greased his skin. He tried to lock his jaw, to physically bite down on the heavy, ragged sound of his own breathing.

Pop.

A gunshot. Distant, but sharp enough to cut cleanly through the roar of the ocean. It echoed off the metal labyrinth.

Vikram was hunting.

Arjun swallowed hard. The back of his throat was raw, tasting sharply of copper and the bitter, burnt remnants of the coffee he had thrown. He needed to move. He needed to push deeper into the maze. But his legs were trembling, the quadriceps twitching involuntarily from the adrenaline dump and the sheer physical shock of falling out of a moving Ambassador.

He opened his eyes. The darkness between the containers was nearly absolute. The pale, sickly yellow light from the streetlamps didn't penetrate this deep into the stacks.

He pushed off the steel wall, taking a hesitant, limping step forward.

A hand clamped over his mouth.

It was rough, stinking intensely of old grease and crushed cardamom. Before Arjun could react, a second hand grabbed the soaked collar of his suit jacket. He was yanked violently backward.

He thrashed. He threw his left elbow backward, aiming for ribs. It connected with something solid, but the grip on his mouth didn't loosen. Instead, a heavy arm wrapped entirely around his chest, pinning his arms to his sides.

"Stop," a voice hissed directly into his ear. It was a woman's voice. Frantic. Wet. "If you scream, the Enforcer hears you. Shut up."

Arjun fought, twisting his neck, his boots slipping on the wet stones.

He was dragged backward, into the seemingly solid wall of the container. But he didn't hit steel. He was pulled

through a jagged, rusted-out hole in the side of the metal box. The sharp, rusted edges of the corrugated iron tore a wide gash through the sleeve of his wool jacket.

He was thrown hard to the floor. The ground here wasn't cobblestone; it was warped, rotting wood.

The hand left his mouth.

Arjun scrambled backward like a crab, pushing himself into a corner. The air inside the container was stifling, completely dead. It smelled powerfully of rat droppings, rotting fish meal, and the sharp, chemical bite of kerosene.

"Light it," the woman's voice said.

A match struck. The sulfur flared, momentarily blinding him.

A cracked glass lantern caught the flame, casting a low, sputtering orange light across the enclosed space.

Arjun pressed his spine against the back wall, his chest heaving, his eyes darting frantically.

There were three of them.

The woman who had grabbed him was crouching near the lantern. She looked entirely out of place for a 1965

dockyard. She wore a torn, faded saree, but that wasn't the weird part. The weird part was the distinct, glowing neon-blue barcode flickering rapidly on the side of her neck. It wasn't a tattoo. It was light. It stuttered and shifted, casting a faint blue reflection on her jawline.

To her left stood a man. He was incredibly tall, wearing the heavy, brass-buttoned red coat of an 18th-century British colonial soldier. But he was physically failing. His left arm from the elbow down lacked all color. It was completely desaturated, rendered in flat, grainy grayscale.

The third was a teenage boy, squatting on a wooden crate. He wore a modern, synthetic hoodie. He was holding a heavy, rusted iron pipe tightly in both hands. He didn't look at Arjun's face. He stared directly at the center of Arjun's chest.

"He's wearing the charcoal suit," the boy said. His voice trembled. He adjusted his grip on the iron pipe, the metal grinding loudly against his callouses. "He's an Enforcer. You brought an Enforcer inside."

"I am not," Arjun gasped. He coughed, leaning forward, holding his ribs. "I'm not."

"Shut up," the grayscale soldier snapped. He stepped forward. His heavy leather boots made absolutely no sound against the wooden floorboards. The absence of the

auditory feedback made Arjun's stomach churn. "You wear the cut. You smell like Kaal Nath."

"Kaal Nath wants me dead," Arjun fired back. His voice was gaining strength, fueled by sheer, desperate confusion. He pointed a trembling finger toward the rusted hole in the wall. "Vikram... the guy out there with the gun. He just tried to put a bullet through my chest."

The woman with the barcode tilted her head. The neon light on her neck glitched, turning a static-filled white for a second before snapping back to blue.

"Enforcers shoot each other," she said, her tone flat, analytical. She picked at a loose thread on her saree. "It happens when the localized code gets tangled. They reset each other. It's standard systemic maintenance."

"I'm not maintenance!" Arjun yelled. He immediately dropped his voice to a harsh whisper, remembering the gun out in the rain. "I'm a physicist. My name is Arjun Verma."

The three of them went completely still.

The silence in the rotting container stretched. The rain hammered against the steel roof above them, a deafening drumbeat.

The boy slowly lowered the iron pipe. The end of it

clanked softly against the wooden floor.

"You're lying," the soldier said softly. But he didn't step any closer. He actually took a half-step back. "001 was deleted. Kaal Nath scrubbed the Mughal node entirely."

"He missed," Arjun said. He swallowed hard. The memory of the void, the heavy, dark oil, the static. "I... I hid in the static. Or Rishi did. I don't... I don't fully understand the mechanics of the transition yet."

Arjun looked at his smooth hands, then up at the impossible, glitching people standing around him. The absurdity of it all threatened to crack his remaining sanity. A quantum physicist sitting on a rotting floor in a 1965 dockyard, arguing with a grayscale colonial soldier.

"Look," Arjun said, dragging his hands down his face. The rainwater mixed with the sweat. "I was in a lab. In Mumbai. 2026. I turned on a machine. The Ananta Device. And the world... it curdled."

The woman leaned forward. She brought the lantern closer to Arjun's face. The heat of the glass radiated against his cold skin. Her dark eyes searched his features meticulously, looking for a seam, a flaw in the rendering.

"What did the sky look like?" she asked. Her voice was barely a whisper. "When the lab broke. What color was the

storm?"

Arjun didn't hesitate. He could still smell the rotting flowers. He could still feel the burn of the phantom blade.

"Saffron," Arjun said. "It turned deep, blood-soaked saffron."

The woman exhaled a long, shaky breath. She set the lantern down on the floorboards.

"It's him," she said, looking up at the soldier. "He remembers the origin."

"It could be a trap," the soldier argued, though the conviction was entirely gone from his voice. He rubbed his grayscale arm, a nervous, repetitive tick. "The Oracle uses templates. She wears faces. She could be wearing his data to flush us out."

"The Oracle," Arjun repeated. The name tasted like poison. "She was there. In the saffron storm. She said... she said she was the ending."

"She's the Warden," the boy on the crate said bitterly. He spat onto the floor. "She locks the doors. We're the garbage she missed when she sweeps the floors."

Arjun pushed himself up until he was sitting against the

corrugated wall. The rust flaked off onto his wet suit.

"Who are you people?" he asked.

"We are errors," the woman said. She sat back on her heels. "Echoes. Glitches. People who survived a hard reset but lost our primary coordinates. I was supposed to die in a train derailment in 1992. Tariq," she pointed to the soldier, "was supposed to catch a musket ball in 1757. The system tried to delete us, but the code hung. We slipped through the cracks."

She touched the flickering blue barcode on her neck.

"The system doesn't know what to do with us anymore. So it dumps us here. In the dead zones. The places where the script is thin."

"And Vikram?" Arjun asked. "Kaal Nath?"

"They are the antivirus," Tariq said. The grayscale soldier crossed his arms. "They patrol the edges. If they find an Echo, they execute a manual deletion. If they find you... they'll burn this entire node to the ground to ensure the scrub."

"Then I need to get out of this node," Arjun said. He forced his legs under him, using the wall to stand up. His right knee throbbed violently, a sharp spike of pain that made him wince. "How do I get back? Or forward? How do

I get to the Zero Point?"

The woman looked at Tariq. Tariq looked at the floor.

"You don't," the boy said quietly.

"Why not?"

"Because the map is locked," the woman explained. She picked up the lantern again. The orange light cast deep shadows under her eyes, making her look incredibly old despite her smooth skin. "This is 1965 Bombay. The system has physically walled off the geographic and temporal boundaries. If you run too far south, you don't hit the ocean. You hit the render limit."

"The edge of the map," Arjun murmured, remembering Vikram's warning outside the car.

"It's a solid wall of code," Tariq said. "Looks like ancient stone. Smells like jasmine and blood. You can't climb it. You can't break it."

Arjun closed his eyes.

The wall is a lie. Rishi's voice echoed in the cavernous space of his memory. *Push.*

"Show me," Arjun said. He opened his eyes, looking

directly at the woman. "Show me the edge."

"If we move, the Enforcer finds us," Tariq warned.

"If we stay, he finds us anyway," Arjun countered. He stepped away from the wall. His wet suit hung heavily on his frame, dripping muddy water onto the rotting floorboards. "He has a gun. He has the systemic authority. But I have the Anomaly code. If the system is trying this hard to kill me, it means I have the leverage to break it."

The woman stared at him. The barcode on her neck pulsed a steady, bright blue.

She turned to the boy. "Open the back hatch, Dev."

The boy nodded. He jumped off the crate, his sneakers squeaking against the wet wood. He walked to the far end of the shipping container and threw his weight against a heavy iron latch. It screamed in protest, a loud, metallic shriek of rusted hinges.

The heavy door swung outward, revealing a narrow, pitch-black alleyway between the stacks. The rain roared outside, waiting for them.

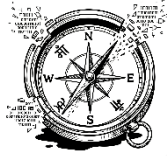
"Keep your head down," the woman said to Arjun, grabbing the lantern. "And whatever you do, do not look directly at the sky when we reach the boundary. It will

induce a seizure."

Arjun didn't argue. He buttoned his torn, ruined suit jacket.

He stepped out of the rotting container and back into the freezing, driving rain.

CHAPTER 9



The Investigation

The windshield wipers dragged across the glass. A dry, awful squeak.

Aditi turned the ignition off. The engine of her sedan shuddered once, then died, plunging the cabin into absolute, suffocating silence. She sat in the driver's seat. The underground parking garage of the Verma Institute of Quantum Sciences was a vast, echoing cavern of gray concrete and flickering fluorescent strips. It smelled of cold exhaust, damp cement, and the bitter tang of old engine oil.

She stared at the steering wheel. Her knuckles were bone-white.

"Okay," she whispered. Her voice cracked. A dry, pathetic sound in the empty car. "Okay. Just... go inside."

She didn't move.

Her right hand rested on the passenger seat, her fingers tangled tightly in the stiff, water-resistant fabric of her trench coat. Her thumb rubbed repeatedly over the small, melted hole near the hem. The scorch mark. The tiny, microscopic scent of baking sulfur that proved she wasn't clinically insane.

Dr. Rao had left her a voicemail an hour ago. His tone was careful. Practiced. He had driven to her apartment, found it empty, and urged her to call him back immediately so they could discuss the "anniversary of the accident."

There was no accident. Arjun didn't die on the Sea Link three years ago. He was here, in this building, yesterday.

She let go of the coat. She grabbed her heavy canvas tote bag from the floorboard and pushed the car door open. The hinges groaned loudly.

The air in the garage was freezing. It bit through her thin cotton sweater, raising goosebumps on her forearms. She slammed the door shut. The sound echoed off the concrete pillars, rebounding into the darkness. She walked toward the steel security door leading to the service elevators. Her rubber-soled boots squeaked against the slick, painted concrete. *Squeak. Squeak.* The noise grated against her raw nerves.

She reached the door. Next to the heavy metal handle was a black digital keypad and a magnetic card reader. A small red LED blinked lazily.

She dug into her tote bag. Her fingers scraped past a loose pen, a half-empty pack of gum, and finally touched the cold, rigid plastic of Arjun's old security badge. She had kept it. She didn't know why. Dr. Rao had suggested throwing it away to aid the grieving process. She had lied and said she did.

She pulled it out. Dr. Arjun Verma. His ID photo stared back at her. He looked so incredibly tired, even then.

Her hand shook. She swiped the card through the magnetic slot.

Beep-boop. The LED flashed angry red. Access Denied.

Her breath hitched. "Come on," she muttered. She wiped the magnetic strip aggressively against her sweater. She swiped it again, faster.

Beep-boop. Red.

"Please." Her vision blurred. Hot, stinging tears threatened to spill. She swallowed hard, forcing the heavy lump of panic back down her throat. She gripped the plastic

card so tightly it bowed in the middle. She took a slow, jagged breath, aligning the magnetic strip perfectly with the reader.

She pulled it through. Slow. Steady.

Click. The LED flared a solid, welcoming green. The heavy magnetic lock inside the steel door disengaged with a dull thud.

Aditi yanked the handle down and pulled. The heavy door dragged open.

She stepped into the service corridor. The air here was entirely different. It was the aggressively filtered, climate-controlled atmosphere of the Institute. It smelled of industrial floor wax and the faint, metallic scent of ozone.

She bypassed the main lobby entirely. If the system was actively overwriting reality, she didn't want to know if Prakash, the night guard, was sitting at the front desk with a newly fabricated set of memories. She couldn't handle looking a man in the eye and seeing a stranger's programmed lie looking back.

She took the service elevator.

The metal box smelled like bleach. The ride up to the seventh floor was agonizingly slow. The mechanical hum of

the cables vibrated through the soles of her boots. She stared at the brushed steel doors, watching her own warped reflection. Dark circles bruised the skin under her eyes. Her hair was a messy, tangled knot.

Ding.

The doors slid open.

The seventh floor was dark. Only the emergency track lighting along the baseboards illuminated the long hallway. Aditi stepped out. The silence here was heavy, pressurized.

She walked down the corridor. Her destination was at the very end. The reinforced glass double doors.

She stood in front of them. The lab.

Beyond the thick glass, the room was bathed in the faint, ambient glow of sleeping monitors. The massive brass and chrome bulk of the Ananta Device sat dead in the center of the room. Its rotating iris was completely still.

She pushed the glass doors open. They didn't hiss. They just swung inward heavily.

The lab felt entirely dead. The low, throbbing hum of the server banks was gone. The machines had been physically powered down.

Aditi walked directly to Arjun's sprawling mahogany desk.

She didn't turn on the overhead spots. She didn't want to attract attention from the street below. She pulled his heavy leather chair out and sat down. The cushion was cold.

A single, primary monitor sat on the desk. She reached out and pressed the power button on the tower below.

The fans whirled to life. A soft, mechanical sigh. The screen flared, casting a harsh, pale blue light across her face. It hurt her eyes. She squinted, bringing her hands up to rub her temples.

The login screen appeared.

User: A.Verma. Password:

She stared at the blinking cursor.

Arjun was a physicist. He didn't use birthdays. He didn't use anniversaries. He used constants.

She placed her cold fingers on the mechanical keyboard. The keys clicked sharply as she typed.

Planck1900. Enter.

Incorrect password.

She bit the inside of her cheek, tasting copper. She tried again.

Schrodinger8. Enter.

Incorrect password.

"Think," she whispered to the empty room. "What were you obsessing over? What was in your head?"

She closed her eyes. She pictured him sitting in this exact chair, rubbing his jaw, staring at the blueprints. What had he said to her right before the machine activated?

The resonance frequency is off by 0.04 percent.

She opened her eyes. She typed, her fingers flying over the keys.

Resonance0.04

She hit Enter.

The screen froze for a microsecond. Then, the lock icon unclicked. The desktop loaded.

Aditi exhaled a breath she didn't realize she had been holding. Her shoulders slumped.

She grabbed the mouse. The desktop was chaotic. Dozens of folders, scattered text files, unrendered CAD blueprints. She ignored the physics simulations. She didn't understand the math, and the math wasn't what had erased her husband.

She clicked on the primary hard drive icon. She was looking for the paper trail. The Verma Institute had spent billions on this project. Billions of dollars didn't just materialize. There were grants, audits, oversight committees. If the machine was a cage, someone paid for the steel.

She opened the financial directory.

Folder: Funding Initial.

She double-clicked it. The screen populated with hundreds of PDF invoices and bank transfer logs.

She opened the oldest file. 2016. A massive wire transfer. Six hundred million rupees.

She tracked her eyes to the 'Originating Account' column. It wasn't the Ministry of Science. It wasn't a university endowment.

It was a shell corporation. *Apex Solutions Ltd.*

Aditi frowned. She copied the name, opened a secure browser window, and pasted it into the search bar.

The results were sparse. A holding company registered in a tax haven in Cyprus. A single, static webpage with a generic corporate logo and no contact information.

She clicked back to the directory. She opened the next invoice. 2018. Another massive injection of capital.

Originating Account: Horizon Logistics.

She searched it. Another shell. Registered in Panama.

She spent the next forty minutes falling down the rabbit hole. The blue glare of the monitor burned her retinas. Her eyes watered, but she didn't blink. The silence of the lab pressed against her eardrums, but she ignored it.

Every single rupee that had funded the Ananta Device came from a sprawling, impossibly complex web of ghost companies. Dozens of them. They fed into each other, masking the true origin point of the capital.

She opened a new text document and started typing out the names, trying to build a map.

Apex. Horizon. Zenith Management. The O.R.A.C.L.E. Trust.

She stopped typing.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard.

The Oracle.

I am the ending, the woman made of smoke had said.

A cold, heavy dread settled directly into the pit of her stomach. The simulation wasn't just a digital construct somewhere in the ether. It had physical roots. It had a corporate structure in the real world. The Wardens were funding their own cage.

She clicked back to the main directory. She scrolled past the financial folders.

At the very bottom of the list, hidden beneath hundreds of mundane administrative files, was a single folder with no name. Just a blank icon.

She hovered the cursor over it. The mouse felt slick with her sweat.

She double-clicked.

A password prompt appeared. Not the system login. A secondary encryption lock.

Enter Decryption Key:

Aditi dragged a hand down her face. She was exhausted. The caffeine withdrawal was causing a dull, throbbing ache at the base of her skull. "I don't know this one, Arjun," she murmured.

She tried *Resonance0.04* again. Denied.

She tried her own name. Denied.

She sat back in the heavy leather chair. She looked around the darkened lab. The shadows in the corners seemed to stretch, hiding things she couldn't quite see. She looked at the Ananta Device. The brass iris.

She looked down at the desk. Underneath the edge of the keyboard, barely visible, was a small, torn piece of masking tape.

Arjun used to write things on tape when he ran out of sticky notes.

She leaned closer. The ink was faded, smudged by the friction of his wrists resting against the desk.

Sbj_001.

Subject 001.

Aditi sat up. She pulled the keyboard toward her. She typed *Sbj_001* into the prompt.

Decryption successful.

The folder opened.

It didn't contain spreadsheets. It contained audio files. Hundreds of them. Labeled simply by date.

She clicked on the most recent one. Dated three days ago.

The media player opened. A waveform appeared on the screen. She found a pair of heavy, noise-canceling headphones resting on the edge of the desk. She picked them up, her hands trembling, and slid them over her ears. The foam padding blocked out the dead silence of the lab completely.

She clicked play.

A sharp burst of static hissed through the headphones, making her wince. Then, a voice.

"Log entry... seventy-three. I think."

It was Arjun.

Hearing his voice—real, un-simulated, exhausted—hit her like a physical punch to the throat. A tear spilled over her lower lid, tracking hot and fast down her cheek. She didn't wipe it away.

"The hallucinations are escalating," Arjun's recorded voice continued. He sounded frantic, the words tumbling over each other. *"Not hallucinations. That's the wrong word. Data bleeds. I tasted poisoned wine today. My tongue went completely numb. I smelled burning hair in the cafeteria. It's the Ananta. The machine isn't creating a gateway. It's attempting to pierce the render limit."*

Aditi gripped the edge of the desk. *Render limit.*

"The funding," Arjun's voice dropped to a harsh whisper. There was the distinct sound of a coffee mug being set down on wood. *"I looked into the capital flow. The board of directors. The names are fabricated. All of them except one. The primary signatory for the Zenith shell. K. Nath."*

Aditi's breath caught. She scrambled for the mouse, opening her text document again to type the name.

"Kaal Nath," Arjun said. The name dripped with a heavy, irrational terror. *"I don't know who he is, but the name... it triggers a pain response in my amygdala. Every time I read it, my chest hurts."*

A phantom scar."

The audio log paused. Aditi heard the heavy, ragged sound of Arjun taking a deep breath.

"They know I'm close," he whispered. "Aditi keeps begging me to stop. She cries. God, she cries so much, and it breaks me. But yesterday... yesterday she looked at me, and her eyes just... went dead. For a fraction of a second. The empathy shut off. Like a subroutine crashing. They are using her, or they are wearing her. I don't know what's real anymore. I have to turn it on. I have to see the code."

The recording ended in a sharp click of static.

Aditi sat frozen. The heavy drag of air in her lungs felt inadequate. She was suffocating in the sterile lab.

Like a subroutine crashing.

He thought she wasn't real. Or worse, the system had actively hijacked her face to manipulate him.

She ripped the headphones off. She threw them onto the desk. They clattered loudly against the plastic casing of the monitor.

She stared at the name she had just typed on the screen.

Kaal Nath.

He wasn't just an Enforcer in some historical, glitching timeline. He was a physical entity. A signatory. A man with a bank account and a corporate footprint in 2026 Mumbai.

Aditi stood up. The leather chair scraped violently backward.

She wasn't crazy. Arjun wasn't dead. He was trapped in the machine they had built.

And she knew exactly whose door she needed to kick down to find the key.

CHAPTER 10



The Edge of the Map

The rain hit him like a handful of gravel.

Arjun stepped out of the rusted container and immediately sank ankle-deep into a puddle of freezing, oily water. The cold bypassed his skin entirely, settling deep into the marrow of his bones. His charcoal suit, already ruined, dragged against his shoulders. It felt like wearing a wet rug.

Dev, the teenager in the synthetic hoodie, was already moving. He didn't look back. He slipped between two towering stacks of steel, his sneakers squeaking faintly.

"Keep your head down," Maya muttered. She brushed past Arjun. The neon-blue barcode on her neck pulsed rapidly, a frantic, stuttering rhythm that cast a sickly blue glow on the falling raindrops.

Tariq brought up the rear. The grayscale soldier moved with a terrifying lack of physics. His heavy leather boots struck the wet cobblestones, but there was no splash. No heavy thud. It was like watching a film strip with the audio track completely severed. Arjun watched Tariq's desaturated, gray hand grip the edge of a rusted shipping container. The rust didn't flake onto his skin. He didn't quite interact with the world. He just existed on top of it.

Arjun swallowed hard. His throat tasted of copper and bile. He forced his right leg forward. The knee throbbed. A sharp, localized spike of pain that made him bite the inside of his cheek.

They moved deeper into the labyrinth.

The Bombay docks were a massive, chaotic graveyard of forgotten logistics. Stacks of shipping crates leaned at precarious angles, forming narrow, claustrophobic canyons. The sickly yellow light from the distant streetlamps couldn't penetrate the heavy steel canopy. The only illumination was the erratic blue stutter from Maya's neck and the occasional, blinding flash of lightning that ripped across the sky.

Arjun dragged his hand along the corrugated wall of a container to keep his balance. The metal was freezing. Wet rust flaked off, sticking to his numb fingers.

"How far?" Arjun rasped, his chest heaving. The heavy

air burned his lungs.

"Shut up," Tariq hissed from behind.

Dev stopped suddenly, his hand shooting up in a fist.

Arjun slammed his back against the wet steel, holding his breath. Maya crouched low, her hand covering the barcode on her neck, plunging them into near-absolute darkness.

Footsteps.

They weren't the erratic, splashing sounds of dockworkers running through the storm. They were synchronized. Heavy, polished dress shoes striking the wet pavement in perfect, unyielding unison.

Click-clack. Click-clack.

"Systemic cleaners," Maya whispered. Her voice was a thin, terrified thread. She pressed her forehead against her knees. "They brought a sweep team."

A beam of harsh, white light cut through the rain. A flashlight. It swept across the entrance of the alleyway they had just crossed, illuminating the driving rain in stark relief.

"Spread out," a voice commanded.

It was Vikram.

Arjun flinched. The voice wasn't just close; it was amplified, carrying an unnatural, metallic resonance that vibrated against the shipping containers.

"You can't outrun the edge of the map, Arjun!" Vikram yelled into the storm. "The node is sealed. We are shutting the grid down."

Arjun squeezed his eyes shut. His heart hammered a frantic, irregular rhythm against his ribs. *He's going to find us. He's going to put a bullet in my head.* He pictured the matte-black revolver. He pictured the dead, empty look in Vikram's eyes.

Tariq's grayscale hand clamped down hard on Arjun's shoulder.

Arjun gasped, his eyes snapping open. Tariq's grip didn't feel like human skin. It felt like cold, dry static. A vibration that numbed the nerve endings in Arjun's collarbone.

Tariq didn't speak. He just pointed down the narrow gap between the containers. *Move.*

They crawled. The ground here was slick with spilled diesel and rotting fish scales. Arjun's ruined suit absorbed the filth. The smell was overpowering, a gag-inducing mixture of industrial waste and salt. He kept his eyes on the

heels of Maya's bare feet, watching the muscles in her calves flex as she scrambled silently over discarded wooden pallets.

Crack.

Lightning flashed. A massive, jagged tear of white.

In that microsecond of illumination, Arjun looked up.

The geometry of the alleyway was wrong.

The towering red shipping container directly to his right hadn't just rusted; it had warped. The sharp, right angles of corrugated steel were softening, bulging outward.

"Wait," Arjun breathed. He stopped crawling. "Look at the wall."

"Don't look at the rendering," Maya hissed, turning back and grabbing his wrist. "I told you. Keep your head down."

But Arjun couldn't.

The world blinked.

It wasn't a metaphor. The physical environment literally stuttered, a massive dropped frame in the visual feed.

It started with the sound. The rhythmic, splashing *thud-thud-thud* of his heavy leather boots on the wet asphalt

changed mid-step.

He shifted his weight, and the sound was a hollow, dry *clack-clack-clack*. The distinct, sharp noise of wooden sandals striking dry stone.

Arjun stumbled forward. The sudden, violent shift in friction threw him entirely off balance. His foot expected wet, slick asphalt. It found packed, dusty earth.

He pitched sideways, throwing his hands out to catch himself against the side of the shipping container.

His palms didn't slap against cold, wet metal.

They scraped aggressively against rough, sun-baked sandstone.

He gasped, yanking his hands back as if he had just touched a hot stove. He stared at his palms. They were coated in a fine, red dust.

He looked up.

The towering red shipping container was completely gone. In its place stood a massive, crumbling wall of ancient masonry. Thick, green moss crept up the cracks in the stone. Faded, peeling frescoes of charging war elephants and celestial dancers stretched across the surface, their paint

flaking in the dry air. The heavy steel rivets that had held the container together were now massive iron brackets, pitted and rusted by centuries of exposure, not sea salt.

"No..." Arjun whispered. The word scratched his throat. He backed away. "No, no, no..."

He looked down. The asphalt—the black, oil-slicked road of 1965 Bombay—was gone. He was standing on hard-packed dirt.

The smell of diesel, dead fish, and heavy rain vanished in an instant. The air hitting his face was thick. Hot. Bone-dry. It smelled overwhelmingly of cloying, sweet jasmine, the rotting scent of crushed marigolds, and the heavy, unmistakable copper tang of old blood.

He looked up at the sky.

The heavy, black monsoon clouds had evaporated. Above him was a sprawling twilight sky, a bruised, ugly mixture of purple and orange. It was choked with thick, black smoke rising from distant fires.

Down the alley, the neon sign of a hotel that had been flickering in the 1965 rain suddenly twisted. The glass tubes elongated, warped, and dissolved into the roaring, chaotic flame of a heavy iron torch held by a stone statue.

"Maya?" Arjun choked out, turning around.

The alley was empty.

Maya, Dev, Tariq—they were gone. The system hadn't brought them over the threshold. They were trapped back in the rain, or they had been deleted.

Thump.

Arjun froze.

He heard footsteps behind him.

They weren't the sharp, synchronized click of polished dress shoes on wet pavement. They were heavy. Rhythmic. Brutal. The distinct, terrifying sound of armored boots crushing bone and dry gravel.

Arjun spun around.

At the entrance of the alleyway, blocking his only exit, a silhouette stood against the bruised, dying light.

It was a man. He was wearing the charcoal suit. Vikram.

But as Arjun watched, the shadow shifted. It rippled, exactly like thick oil moving on the surface of water.

The fabric of the 1965 suit hardened. It fused, turning rapidly into interlocking plates of heavy chainmail. The wet fedora melted down over his skull, reshaping itself with a sickening crunch into a heavy, spiked iron helmet. The matte-black revolver in his right hand elongated. The barrel stretched, the metal warping and sharpening until it was a long, curved tulwar, dripping thick with a viscous black liquid.

"THERE IS NO EXIT, TRAVELER."

The voice wasn't Vikram's anymore. The gravelly baritone was gone. It was deeper. Metallic. It sounded like it was being forced through a rusted pipe, overlapping with a thousand other voices screaming in perfect, horrific unison.

"THE FILE IS CORRUPTED. DELETE."

The figure—Kaal Nath, the Enforcer in his true, terrible form—stepped forward. The dry ground physically shook with the weight of the impact.

Arjun backed up. His shoulder hit the dead end. The ancient, impenetrable wall of sandstone masonry. There was nowhere left to run.

"THE WALL IS A LIE! TURN AROUND!"

The static voice in Arjun's head screamed. It was so loud,

so violently abrupt, that Arjun's knees buckled. He dropped, clutching the sides of his head.

"What?" Arjun gasped, looking frantically between the towering monster and the solid rock.

"THE WALL! IT IS JUST CODE! PUSH!"

Kaal Nath raised the heavy, curved sword. The air immediately surrounding the dark steel blade began to crackle, splitting the dry heat with jagged forks of black lightning.

"End of line, Arjun," the Enforcer rumbled.

Arjun looked at the sword. He looked at the black lightning.

He slowly turned his head and looked at the solid, ancient stone wall directly behind him. It looked completely impenetrable. It was covered in moss and history. It looked real.

He reached a trembling hand out and placed his palm flat against the frescoes.

It felt hard. Unyielding. Stone.

"PUSH!" Rishi's voice roared, a desperate, tearing sound

that vibrated the fluid in Arjun's inner ear.

Arjun didn't question it. He couldn't. Logic was a luxury that belonged to the Verma Institute. Logic was dead.

He spun his body toward the rough stone. He squeezed his eyes shut so tight bright colors bloomed behind his eyelids. He planted his right foot in the dirt, ignored the screaming pain in his knee, and threw his entire body weight violently against the ancient masonry.

He fully expected the impact to break his shoulder. He braced himself to hear the sickening crunch of his own collarbone snapping against the rock.

Instead, he fell through.

The heavy stone gave way entirely. It parted exactly like wet paper tearing under pressure.

The sensation was profoundly disgusting. It felt exactly like falling face-first through a thick, freezing membrane of cold gelatin. It coated his skin, filled his ears, and dragged at his clothes.

Arjun tumbled wildly forward, losing all sense of gravity.

He crashed heavily onto a floor. Not dirt. Not asphalt. Cold, polished marble.

He skidded a few feet on his stomach, his breath knocked out of him in a sharp, agonizing *whoosh*.

The roar of the heavy wind, the baking heat of the battlefield, the terrifying, layered voice of the Enforcer—it all cut off instantly.

Silence.

Arjun lay completely flat on the freezing marble. He gasped, his chest heaving, his heart hammering a frantic, dying rhythm against the stone.

He waited for the heavy blade to strike his neck. He waited for the crack of the revolver. He squeezed his eyes tighter, bracing for the deletion.

Nothing. The silence stretched. It was thick. Peaceful.

Slowly, agonizingly, Arjun pushed himself up onto his hands and knees. His muscles screamed in protest. His ruined suit dripped a mixture of 1965 rainwater and 1600s red dirt onto the pristine floor.

He opened his eyes.

CHAPTER 11



The Cursed Chamber

The marble was completely, unforgivingly freezing.

Arjun lay flat against the polished stone, his cheek pressed hard into the unforgiving surface. The cold seeped directly through the ruined, wet wool of his charcoal suit, biting into the skin of his chest and thighs. He didn't move.

He focused entirely on the mechanical act of breathing.

In. Out.

The heavy drag of air scraping down his raw throat sounded monstrously loud. There was no rain here. No thunder. The violent, metallic roar of Kaal Nath's voice was gone. The transition through the wall had severed the audio track of the universe.

Arjun opened his eyes.

The floor beneath him was white marble, heavily veined with dark, smoky gray. It was smooth, worn down by centuries of friction. A single drop of dirty, oil-slicked rainwater detached from his ruined cuff and hit the stone. *Plink.*

He groaned, the sound vibrating in his own chest, and pushed himself up.

His right knee screamed. The joint was stiff, the muscle swollen and throbbing from the impact on the Bombay cobblestones. He ignored it, forcing his legs underneath him. He stayed on his hands and knees for a long moment, his head hanging down between his shoulders. He watched another drop of water fall from his chin. It was muddy. Red dirt mixed with gray rain.

He swallowed hard. His mouth tasted like pennies and ash.

Slowly, he lifted his head.

He was at the center of a vast, circular chamber. The scale of it was dizzying. The ceiling arched high above, a massive dome of dark, unpolished stone that seemed to swallow whatever weak light existed here. The curved walls were lined with thousands of shallow, carved niches. In every single niche sat a small, brass oil lamp.

They were all completely dry. Unlit.

The air in the chamber was entirely dead. No drafts. No ventilation. It smelled deeply of cold dust, ancient, dry rot, and the faint, lingering copper tang of old blood. It was the smell of a tomb that hadn't been opened in centuries.

Except for the fire.

About twenty feet away, sitting in the exact center of the sprawling marble floor, was a small, pathetic campfire. It crackled weakly.

A man sat cross-legged beside it.

Arjun stayed on his knees, his breath hitching. He stared at the figure.

The man did not look up. He was tending the weak flames with the tip of a rusted, broken sword blade, gently nudging a piece of charred wood deeper into the embers. Orange sparks drifted upward, dying instantly in the freezing air.

He wore rags. The fabric was a dull, desaturated gray, but Arjun could see the faded, rigid cut of a military tunic beneath the dirt and wear. Heavy, ornate epaulets hung by single threads from his broad shoulders. His hair was a wild,

matted tangle of black and iron-gray that fell past his collar. His beard was thick, unruly.

He looked entirely hollowed out. A physical manifestation of exhaustion.

"You're dripping on the floor," the man said.

His voice was a dry, scraping rasp. It didn't echo in the cavernous room. It just hit the air and sank.

Arjun flinched. He knew that voice.

It wasn't distorted by analog static anymore. It wasn't screaming over the roar of a void. But the cadence was identical. The heavy, authoritative weight behind the words.

I AM THE GHOST.

Arjun dragged himself backward, his boots squeaking horribly against the polished marble. He managed to get his feet under him, using a massive, cold stone pillar to haul his body weight up. His knee buckled, but he caught himself, leaning heavily against the rock.

"You..." Arjun coughed. The dust in the air coated the back of his throat. He cleared it, spitting a small wad of gray saliva onto the floor. He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. "You're the voice. The static."

The man finally stopped poking the fire.

He rested the broken blade across his lap. He turned his head slowly.

His eyes caught the firelight. They were sharp. A piercing, terrifyingly intelligent amber that looked entirely out of place in a face so ruined by time. They were the eyes of a predator forced to live in a cage for four hundred years.

"I told you to push," the man said. He didn't smile. He didn't offer a hand. He just stared at Arjun's ruined suit. "I was beginning to think you were going to let him shoot you again. You hesitated. You always hesitate."

Arjun rubbed his temples. The dull ache at the base of his skull was expanding, threatening to split his head in two.

"I don't..." Arjun trailed off. He looked around the impossible room, the thousands of unlit lamps. He looked back at the ragged soldier. "Shoot me again? I don't know you."

"No," the man agreed softly. He picked up the broken blade and returned to the fire. "But I know you, Dr. Verma."

Arjun's breath caught. He pushed away from the pillar, limping one step closer to the fire. The heat radiating from

the small flames was incredibly weak, but it felt like a miracle against his freezing, wet skin.

"How do you know my name?" Arjun asked. His voice trembled. He hated that it trembled, but he couldn't stop it. "Who are you?"

The man sighed. A long, heavy exhalation that seemed to carry the weight of centuries.

"My name is Rishi Malhotra," he said, his eyes fixed on the burning embers. "Or, at least, that is the designation the system assigned to me. General of the Northern Plains. The Unbreaking Shield."

He let out a short, bitter bark of laughter. It sounded like grinding stones.

"A shield," Rishi muttered, shaking his head. "What a joke. I couldn't protect anything. Least of all myself."

Arjun took another step closer. He could see the deep, carved lines in Rishi's face. He wasn't a hologram. He wasn't a glitching, desaturated echo like Tariq. He was solid. Real. The fire cast deep, leaping shadows across his cheekbones.

"Rishi," Arjun repeated. The name felt heavy on his tongue. He remembered the Mughal armor. The goblet of poisoned wine. The absolute, crushing heartbreak he had

felt floating in the void. "You... I felt you. When I was in the dark. I felt your memories."

Rishi looked up. The amber eyes locked onto Arjun.

"You didn't feel my memories, Arjun," Rishi said quietly. "You felt the echo of the hardware failing. When they delete you, the code doesn't just vanish cleanly. It bleeds. It stains the sectors around it. You caught the runoff."

"Delete me?" Arjun shook his head rapidly. "No. No, I was in a lab. I was running a calibration on a particle accelerator. The resonance frequency spiked. It was a mechanical failure."

"Stop it."

Rishi's voice cracked like a whip. The sudden volume startled Arjun, making him take a step back.

Rishi pushed himself up from the floor. His joints popped loudly in the quiet room. He was tall. Broad-shouldered. Even wrapped in dirty rags, he moved with the terrifying, coiled grace of a man who had spent his entire life killing other men.

He walked around the fire, stopping three feet from Arjun. He smelled like burning wood and stale sweat.

"Stop clinging to the lie," Rishi commanded. He pointed a thick, calloused finger at Arjun's chest. Right at the spot where the phantom sword had struck. "You aren't a scientist making a breakthrough. You aren't a pioneer. You are a prisoner rattling the bars of his cage."

Arjun looked down at Rishi's finger. He felt the phantom ache flare up again.

"A cage," Arjun whispered. He looked away, staring at the dark, curved wall of the chamber. He thought of Aditi. Her terrified eyes in the lab. Her begging him to turn the machine off. *Let's just sleep.* "If this is a cage," Arjun said, his voice tightening, "then what is the Ananta Device?"

"A crowbar," Rishi said bluntly. "And you finally shoved it into the right crack. That's why the Wardens panicked. That's why the sky turned saffron, and that's why they sent Kaal Nath to scrub you."

Arjun swallowed hard. He looked back at Rishi.

"You said... you said Kaal Nath erased you. Scrubbed you." Arjun gestured weakly to Rishi's solid form. "But you're here. You're physically standing in front of me."

Rishi's expression shifted. The anger dissolved, replaced by a profound, hollow sadness. He looked down at his own hands. They were scarred, thick with calluses from a lifetime

of gripping a sword hilt.

"I am what's left," Rishi said softly. His voice lost its aggressive edge. "The rest... the life I had, the men I commanded, the woman I loved... it was overwritten. I was supposed to quietly dissolve into the new update. But I was stubborn."

He lowered his hands.

"I clawed my way into the cracks between the seconds," Rishi explained, walking slowly back toward the fire. The heat distorted the air around him. "I became a ghost in the machine. A fragment of corrupted data hiding in a pocket dimension the system forgot to empty."

He sat back down, crossing his legs with a heavy groan.

"I have sat in this room, Arjun, for four hundred years," Rishi whispered. He picked up the broken blade again. "Watching the loop reset. Watching you wake up."

Arjun's breath hitched.

"Watching me?"

Rishi nodded slowly. He didn't look up from the fire.

"Every time," Rishi said. "Every single lifetime."

Arjun felt the cold marble through the soles of his boots. He felt the wet weight of his 1965 suit. He felt the phantom scar on his chest. His mind, trained for decades to find logic, to balance the quantum equation, violently rejected the variables being presented to him.

"That's impossible," Arjun said. He walked closer, stopping right at the edge of the fire's warmth. He rubbed his face, his fingers pressing hard into his cheekbones. "I am thirty-four years old. I was born in Pune. I have memories. I have a wife."

"Aditi," Rishi said.

The name hung in the air between them.

Arjun froze. "Don't."

"She is beautiful," Rishi continued, his voice entirely devoid of malice. "She loves you. She anchors you. And every single time you start to remember the truth, every time you start to look at the strings holding you up... she begs you to stop."

Arjun's hands dropped to his sides. His fists clenched.

"How do you know her name?" Arjun demanded, his voice dropping to a dangerous, low pitch.

Rishi finally looked up. The amber eyes were entirely devoid of pity. They were flat. Cold.

"Because she is the template, Arjun," Rishi said. "The Oracle needs you docile. She needs you distracted. So she builds you a perfect anchor."

"You're lying."

"She uses the same face," Rishi pushed, his voice rising, gaining that rough, static-edged urgency. "She uses the same voice. I saw her in the Saffron storm, Arjun! I saw the Warden step out of the code. Who did she look like?"

Arjun couldn't breathe.

The memory hit him. The woman woven from smoke. The ageless face. The terrifying, profound sorrow in her eyes as she raised her hand to delete his reality.

Underneath the ancient robes, underneath the smoke... the facial structure, the slope of the jaw.

It was Aditi.

"No," Arjun whispered. He stumbled backward, away from the fire. The heat suddenly felt suffocating. "No, she isn't... Aditi is real. She's real."

"She is a subroutine designed to keep you asleep!" Rishi roared, standing up violently. The fire flared, sparking aggressively. "And you fall for it! Every! Single! Time!"

Rishi stepped over the fire. He closed the distance between them, grabbing Arjun by the soaked lapels of his ruined suit. His grip was iron. Incredibly strong for a ghost.

"You think this is your first time breaking the code?" Rishi asked, his face inches from Arjun's. He smelled of rot and desperation. "You think you are the first version of Arjun Verma to wake up?"

Arjun tried to pull away, to break the grip, but his muscles were completely spent. He was running on empty fumes of adrenaline.

"Let go of me," Arjun rasped.

Rishi didn't let go. He leaned closer, his amber eyes burning into Arjun's.

"By the script, Arjun," Rishi hissed. "You are erased by the very thing you are trying to read. You think you are the anomaly. You are just the latest casualty."

Rishi shoved him.

Arjun stumbled backward, his boots sliding on the slick marble. He caught his balance, chest heaving, staring at the wild, broken General.

Rishi didn't attack again. He simply turned around.

He walked toward the far wall of the circular chamber. The darkness clung to the edges of the room, thick and impenetrable. Rishi reached into one of the brass niches. He pulled out a long, wooden torch, the end wrapped in thick, oil-soaked rags.

He brought it to the campfire, holding it to the embers until the oil caught.

Whoosh.

A bright, aggressive orange flame roared to life, casting harsh, moving shadows across the cavernous room.

Rishi turned back to Arjun. He held the torch high, the firelight catching the feral intensity in his face.

"You want logic, Doctor?" Rishi asked quietly. He turned toward the massive, curved wall of the chamber.

He stepped forward, holding the torch up to the ancient, dark stone.

The light washed over the masonry, pushing the shadows back.

"Here is your logic," Rishi said.

Arjun stopped breathing. He stared at the wall.

It wasn't blank stone.

It was a mural.

CHAPTER 12



The Legacy Mural

The oil-soaked rag snapped and hissed.

It was a wet, ugly sound. Thick drops of burning pitch fell from the torch, hitting the freezing marble floor with a sharp hiss. A thick coil of black smoke rose toward the invisible ceiling, carrying the heavy, nauseating stench of animal fat and sulfur.

Rishi held the wood high. The orange light violently pushed the darkness back, throwing a massive, shuddering arc of illumination against the curved stone wall.

Arjun stopped breathing.

The wall was not blank. It was not simple masonry. It was entirely covered in pigment.

Faded ochre. Deep, crushed lapis lazuli. The dark, rusted brown of dried blood used as a cheap dye. The paint was flaking, cracked by centuries of dry rot and stagnant air, but the image remained.

It was a spiral.

A massive, dizzying fractal that started near the baseboards and coiled upward, consuming the entire seventy-foot height of the chamber wall.

Arjun walked forward. He didn't realize he was moving until the toe of his ruined leather shoe scraped against the marble. He stopped a foot away from the stone. The cold radiating off the ancient rock settled directly into the wet wool of his suit.

He stared at the outer edge of the spiral.

It was a painting of a man. A soldier, wearing heavy, rusted iron plates over a quilted tunic. The man was on his knees in the red dirt. A crude, black arrow protruded directly from the side of his neck. The man's face was twisted in agony, his mouth wide in a silent scream.

Arjun touched his own neck. He felt the rapid, frantic pulse of his carotid artery under his fingertips.

He followed the spiral inward.

The next figure was different. A man wearing the stiff, high-collared red coat of an East India Company officer. He was hanging from a thick hemp rope. The rope was tied to the thick branch of a banyan tree. The man's face was bloated, purple.

The next. A clerk in a 1920s linen suit, lying face down on a rain-slicked cobblestone street. A heavy, dark pool of liquid painted carefully around his head.

The next. A man in a sterile white lab coat. 2026. He was kneeling on a floor of polished obsidian, clutching his chest. A massive, jagged slash of red painted diagonally across his sternum.

Arjun's knees buckled.

He caught himself, slamming his left hand flat against the painted stone. The rough texture bit into his palm. Dust coated his fingers.

"What..." Arjun choked. He swallowed hard, trying to force moisture back into his mouth. "What is this?"

Rishi stood perfectly still. The torchlight cast deep, hollow shadows under his amber eyes. He looked tired. Not sleepy, but a bone-deep, structural fatigue.

"It's a ledger," Rishi said softly. The fire crackled. "A record of failures."

"Failures," Arjun repeated. The word sounded absurd. He stared at the man in the white lab coat. The exact angle of the head. The way the hands clutched the chest. It was a perfect, agonizingly precise rendering of what had happened to him just hours ago. "No. No, it's just a painting. A projection. A... a psychological stress test designed by the system."

"You are a scientist," Rishi countered, his voice flat. He lowered the torch slightly. "You observe data. Stop rejecting the data because it hurts."

Arjun pushed off the wall. He stumbled sideways, following the heavy painted line of the spiral as it tightened toward the center of the massive wall.

Hundreds of them.

Hundreds of iterations. Different clothes. Different eras. Different weapons. But the face was always exactly the same. The slope of the jaw. The dark, heavy brow. The exact arch of the nose.

It was him. Over and over and over again. A terrifying loop of suffering and violent deletion.

"Every time you wake up," Rishi said, his voice trailing Arjun from across the floor. "Every lifetime, you notice the 0.04 percent variance. You hear the static. You push the button, or you drink the wine, or you look behind the curtain. You question reality. And every single time, the system sends an Enforcer to scrub you out."

Arjun reached the center of the spiral.

The paint here was thicker. Darker. It hadn't faded like the outer edges. It looked fresh. It looked wet.

There was only one image in the center. It didn't depict a death.

It depicted a murder.

Arjun stared at the two figures.

It was him again. But he wasn't wearing a suit or a lab coat. He was stripped to the waist, his skin painted a bruised, angry red. He was standing over a woman. His arm was raised high above his head. His hand was tightly gripping the hilt of a long, jagged iron dagger.

The blade was buried entirely to the hilt directly into the woman's chest.

"Why..." Arjun trailed off. His chest heaved. He dragged

a trembling hand through his wet hair. "Why am I killing her?"

"Because she is the Warden," Rishi answered.

Arjun turned his head. Rishi was standing right beside him now. The heat of the torch baked the side of Arjun's face, a sharp contrast to the freezing chamber.

"Look at her face, Arjun," Rishi commanded.

Arjun didn't want to. His stomach churned. A cold, sour dread pooled heavily in his gut. But his eyes moved on their own, tracking down the painted arm, down the iron blade, to the woman lying beneath him.

She wore robes woven from smoke and starlight. Her eyes were open, staring up at the painted ceiling with a profound, terrifying sorrow.

The facial structure. The dark, expressive eyes. The exact curve of her lips.

Aditi.

"No," Arjun whispered. He took a step back. His heel caught the edge of a slight depression in the marble floor. He almost fell. "No. That's... no."

"The Oracle," Rishi said. He didn't sound angry anymore. He sounded broken. "The jailer."

"Aditi isn't a jailer," Arjun snapped, the denial flashing hot and defensive. He pointed a shaking finger at the stone. "She works in publishing. She drinks green tea. She hates the rain. She's my wife."

"She is a snare," Rishi said quietly.

"Shut up!" Arjun yelled. The sound finally echoed, bouncing violently off the high, dark ceiling of the chamber. He grabbed the wet lapels of his own suit, pulling at them as if they were suffocating him. "You don't know her! You're a fragment! You're a glitch sitting in a basement!"

Rishi didn't flinch. He just watched Arjun unravel.

"Four hundred years ago," Rishi began, his voice dropping into a slow, measured cadence. "I walked into the Queen's chambers. I had the sword in my hand. I knew the world was a lie. I saw the neon lines. I heard the machine. I knew Mehrunissa was the anchor keeping me tied to the simulation."

Rishi paused. He swallowed hard. The thick muscles in his neck worked. He looked away from Arjun, staring up at the dark ceiling.

"I raised the blade," Rishi whispered. "I was going to sever the connection. I was going to kill her and break the loop."

He lowered his head. The amber eyes met Arjun's again.

"But I couldn't do it."

Rishi raised his empty left hand. It was trembling. A violent, uncontrollable shake.

"I looked at her face," Rishi said, the words scraping out of his throat. "And I remembered the smell of her hair. I remembered the way she laughed when it rained. I remembered... a thousand tiny, perfect, fabricated details. I lowered the sword. And Kaal Nath stepped out of the shadows and erased me."

Arjun stared at the ragged soldier. The heavy silence of the chamber pressed down on them again.

"You think you are fighting to save the world, Arjun," Rishi said, stepping closer. The smell of burning pitch and old sweat washed over Arjun. "But you aren't. You never are. You are fighting to save her. You run the calculations, you build the machines, you break the timeline... all to find a way out where she gets to come with you."

Rishi pointed the torch directly at the center of the mural.

At the dagger buried in Aditi's chest.

"But she is the lock on the door," Rishi said. "The system is incredibly efficient. It doesn't use iron bars to keep you in the cage. It uses your own gravity. It gives you something you absolutely cannot bear to lose. And it wears that face."

Arjun looked at the painted face of his wife.

He remembered the morning before the calibration. She had burned the toast. She had stood in the kitchen, wearing his oversized university t-shirt, scraping the black char off the bread over the sink. She had looked at him over her shoulder and smiled. A small, quiet, perfectly human smile.

Was that code?

Was the smell of the burnt toast a programmed sensory input? Was her smile just a subroutine executing perfectly to keep his dopamine levels stable so he wouldn't look at the math too closely?

A sharp, physical wave of nausea hit him.

Arjun dropped.

He didn't crouch. His legs simply stopped functioning. He hit the marble floor hard, his knees taking the brunt of the impact. He leaned forward, pressing his forehead against

the freezing stone.

His chest heaved. He dragged air into his lungs, but it wasn't enough. He was hyperventilating.

"She begged me," Arjun gasped into the stone. His voice was muffled, wet. "Yesterday. In the lab. She begged me to turn the machine off."

"Of course she did," Rishi said from above him. The heat of the torch shifted as Rishi moved. "The anomaly was reaching threshold. The system was trying to talk you off the ledge using the most effective voice it had."

"I felt her heartbeat," Arjun sobbed, squeezing his eyes shut. "I put my hands on her chest. I felt her heart beating."

"A tactile rendering," Rishi replied coldly. "A very good one."

Arjun slammed his fist against the marble. "Stop it!"

He pushed himself up onto his knees. He looked up at Rishi. Tears cut clean, hot tracks through the dirt and cold sweat on his face.

"If she's the lock," Arjun demanded, his voice cracking, "why does the mural show me killing her? If I kill her, the loop breaks. Right? So why am I still here?"

Rishi looked at the center image.

"Because that isn't a memory, Arjun," Rishi said quietly. "That is the origin. The first time."

Arjun blinked. "What?"

"The very first iteration," Rishi explained, walking toward the stone. He ran his thick, calloused fingers over the painted dagger. "Before the system trapped us. Before the infinite loop. You broke out. You realized what The Oracle was doing to the universe. And you struck her down."

Rishi turned back to Arjun.

"But you didn't finish it," Rishi said. "You hesitated. For one fraction of a second, you looked at her, and you couldn't push the blade all the way through. And in that microsecond of hesitation... she initiated the Ananta protocol. She trapped your consciousness in an infinite quarantine loop."

Arjun stared at the dagger.

"She forced you to repeat the cycle," Rishi said, his voice dropping to a heavy, crushing whisper. "And to ensure you never had the strength to strike her down again... she wrote herself into your code. She made herself the center of your universe. Every time you wake up, she is your wife. Your

Queen. Your lover."

Rishi crouched down until he was eye level with Arjun.

"The Oracle isn't hiding behind Aditi's face, Arjun," Rishi said. "Aditi *is* The Oracle. A segmented, localized version of her, wiped of her own memories, programmed to love you perfectly so you will never, ever raise the dagger again."

Arjun couldn't speak.

The air in the chamber felt thick, unbreathable. The revelation didn't just break his understanding of physics. It broke the fundamental architecture of his soul.

He wasn't trying to save his wife. His wife was the architect of his hell.

Arjun looked at his own hands. Smooth. Unscarred. He thought of the phantom weight of the iron gauntlet.

"How..." Arjun whispered, staring at his palms. "How do I break it? If she's... if she's the lock."

Rishi stood up. He looked exhausted. He looked like a man who had delivered a death sentence a thousand times.

"You must find the one thing you fear most," Rishi said. He turned his head, looking back toward the absolute darkness at the far edge of the vast chamber. "And you have

to choose it over her."

Crack.

The sound was sharp. It wasn't the hiss of the burning rag. It was a deep, structural groan of heavy stone.

Arjun flinched, his head snapping toward the sound.

A fine dusting of gray powder fell from the massive domed ceiling, drifting down into the torchlight like dirty snow.

BOOM.

The floor vibrated. A heavy, rhythmic shockwave that rattled the unlit brass lamps in their niches.

Rishi's amber eyes widened. He gripped the hilt of his broken sword.

"He found the node," Rishi hissed, backing away from the mural. "The Enforcer."

BOOM.

The heavy stone doors at the far end of the chamber—doors Arjun hadn't even been able to see in the dark—began to splinter.

The silence of the tomb was officially broken.

CHAPTER 13



The Origin of the Enforcer

BOOM.

The sound wasn't just loud. It possessed mass. It pushed a physical wave of displaced air across the vast, freezing expanse of the marble chamber.

Arjun dropped low, throwing his hands over his ears. His ruined knees hit the stone hard. A thick cloud of pulverized mortar and ancient gray dust blew inward from the far end of the room, rolling over the floor like dirty fog. The acrid, dry taste of crushed rock coated the back of his throat. He gagged, coughing violently into the wet, filthy wool of his suit jacket.

BOOM.

A jagged, angry black fissure snapped vertically down the

center of the massive stone doors.

"Rishi!" Arjun yelled. His voice was a raw, scraping sound. He scrambled backward on his hands and knees, his palms slipping on the polished marble. "He's breaking through! Where is the exit? You said there was a rift!"

Rishi didn't move.

The ragged General stood perfectly still, his back to the splintering doors. He was still staring at the mural. At the painted image of the dagger buried in Aditi's chest. The torch in his hand hung loose, the orange flame casting long, erratic shadows across his ruined face.

"There is no exit yet," Rishi said. His voice was terrifyingly calm. Flat. "The rift only opens when the local node collapses completely. We have to wait."

"Wait?" Arjun pushed himself up. His right leg gave out instantly. He caught himself against the painted wall, smearing a thousand-year-old lapis lazuli fresco with the wet mud on his sleeve. "He's going to kill us! He's going to delete us!"

CRACK.

A massive chunk of stone the size of a car engine dislodged from the doorframe. It hit the marble floor with

a deafening crash, fracturing the tiles.

"He can't delete me," Rishi said quietly, turning around.
"I am already a ghost. I have no file left to corrupt."

He walked slowly away from the mural, stepping over the deep fault lines appearing in the floor. He moved toward the dying campfire in the center of the room. He didn't look at the doors.

"Come here," Rishi commanded.

Arjun stared at him. The air in the chamber was visibly vibrating. "Are you insane?"

"Come here, Doctor." It wasn't a request. It was the voice of the Unbreaking Shield.

Arjun swallowed hard. He pushed off the wall. Every step was an agonizing negotiation with his own torn muscles. He limped toward the fire, dragging his right foot. He stopped a few feet from Rishi, keeping his eyes locked on the heavy stone doors across the room. The fissure was widening. A faint, sickly yellow light was beginning to bleed through the crack.

The light of 1965 Bombay. The storm was waiting right outside.

"You need to understand what is coming through that door," Rishi said. He drove the butt of his torch into a crack in the marble floor, lodging it upright. He sat down heavily cross-legged by the embers.

"I know what it is," Arjun gasped, his chest heaving. "It's Kaal Nath. The Enforcer. He's a program. An antivirus."

"He is not a program."

Rishi picked up his broken sword blade. He dragged the rusted iron slowly through the gray ashes of the fire.

"The system doesn't create," Rishi said, his eyes tracking the movement of the blade. "The Oracle is a warden, not a god. She can copy. She can paste. She can trap. But she cannot build a consciousness from scratch. To make an Enforcer... she has to break a human."

BOOM.

The heavy iron hinges of the left door screamed. A high, metallic shriek that made Arjun's teeth ache.

"He was human?" Arjun whispered. He looked down at Rishi. "Kaal Nath?"

"His name was Kabir," Rishi said.

The name hung in the freezing air, absurd and entirely too normal.

"He was a mathematician," Rishi continued, his voice dropping into a slow, rhythmic cadence that seemed to push back against the chaos of the breaking room. "Ninth century. A scholar in the court of the Rashtrakutas. He was brilliant, Arjun. Like you. He looked at the stars, he looked at the geometry of the temples, and he saw the math beneath the paint."

Rishi stopped dragging the blade. He looked up at Arjun.

"He saw the 0.04 percent variance."

Arjun's breath caught. He looked back at the doors. The yellow light bleeding through the crack flickered, casting long, distorted shadows across the dust.

"He woke up," Arjun realized, the horror creeping cold and slow up his spine.

"He woke up," Rishi nodded. "And he ran. He ran further than I ever did. He broke through three separate temporal nodes. He almost found the Zero Point. But the system... it is relentless. It caught him in a dead zone. A place like this. And The Oracle offered him a choice."

"Compliance or extinction," Arjun murmured,

remembering the words he had heard in his own head.

Rishi let out a dry, rattling sigh. "Worse. She offered him an end to the noise."

BOOM.

A horizontal fracture shot across the right door. Dust rained down in thick sheets.

"You know the noise, Doctor," Rishi said. He pointed the broken blade at Arjun's temple. "The static. The bleeding timelines. The absolute, crushing weight of remembering lifetimes you aren't supposed to remember. It burns the mind. It drives you entirely mad."

Arjun rubbed his jaw. He felt the scab there. The scratch he had given himself in the lab, trying to dig the phantom sounds out of his own skull. He knew the noise. He had begged for it to stop just hours ago.

"Kabir begged her to make it stop," Rishi said quietly. "He didn't want to fight anymore. He just wanted the math to balance. He wanted order. So, The Oracle gave him order."

Rishi laid the blade down in the ash.

"The formatting process isn't a physical torture," Rishi

explained, his eyes distant, seeing a memory from centuries ago. "It is a sensory deletion. They strip you. Layer by layer. First, they take the taste of food. Then, the feeling of warmth. The memory of your mother's face. The smell of rain."

Arjun thought of Vikram.

He thought of the Ambassador car. The dead, flat eyes. The complete lack of hesitation as Vikram pulled the hammer back on the revolver.

"Vikram," Arjun choked out. The name felt like ash in his mouth. "Vikram is..."

"A junior process," Rishi confirmed. He didn't offer any comfort. "A localized cleaner. He is halfway through the formatting. He still remembers how to smoke a cigarette. He still feels the burn of hot coffee. But soon, the system will scrub that out, too. Until there is nothing left but the duty."

"That's..." Arjun trailed off, looking away. He stared at the marble floor. "That's worse than death."

"Death is a release, Arjun. The Enforcer is a walking, breathing quarantine. Kaal Nath doesn't hate you. He doesn't feel anger when he hunts you. He feels absolutely nothing. He is just filling a pothole in the road."

CRACK.

The center of the massive stone doors bowed violently inward. The heavy iron brackets holding the ancient wood and stone together shrieked, popping loose like gunshot fire.

Arjun stumbled back from the noise. The vibrations were intense now, shaking the dust from his wet clothes.

"Why are you telling me this?" Arjun yelled over the deafening groan of the failing doors. "What does it matter if he used to be a mathematician? He's a monster now! He's going to kill me!"

Rishi stood up. He didn't use his hands. He just rose, an unbroken, fluid motion.

"I am telling you because you are going to hesitate again," Rishi said. He stepped directly into Arjun's personal space. The amber eyes were blazing. "You are going to look at the liquid metal, you are going to see the monster, and somewhere deep in your pathetic, bleeding heart, you are going to feel pity for Kabir."

Rishi grabbed Arjun's lapels again, shaking him once, hard.

"You cannot pity the machine!" Rishi roared. "If you

hesitate, he will erase you. Not kill you. Erase you. He will rip the code of your existence out of the framework by the roots. Aditi will not remember you. Your mother will not remember you. You will never have been born."

Arjun stared into the ruined face of the General. He felt the cold smudge of sweat on his own forehead. The heavy, suffocating drag of the air in his lungs.

He looked over Rishi's shoulder.

The doors didn't boom this time.

They simply dissolved.

The massive slabs of ancient stone and iron didn't fall forward. They lost their structural integrity entirely, breaking apart into millions of perfectly square, glowing gray pixels. The pixels hovered in the air for a microsecond, a chaotic swarm of digital static, before winking out of existence entirely.

The threshold was completely open.

Beyond the archway, the world was a void of driving, freezing rain and sickly yellow streetlights. The 1965 dockyard had breached the pocket dimension. The smell of wet asphalt and diesel exhaust immediately flooded the tomb, instantly overpowering the scent of old rot and burning pitch.

Standing in the center of the threshold, framed by the storm, was the Enforcer. He wasn't wearing the charcoal suit anymore.

His physical form was shifting. It was deeply, viscerally wrong. It looked like thousands of pounds of liquid mercury desperately trying to hold the shape of a man. The smooth, mirrored surface of his body reflected the erratic orange light of Rishi's torch and the pale yellow of the dockyard. He had no face. No eyes. Just a smooth, featureless dome of shifting liquid heavy metal.

In his right hand, the liquid extended, solidifying into the long, curved, pitch-black blade of a tulwar.

In his left hand, resting gently against his chest plate, was a small, intricate gold pocket watch. The glass face was cracked.

Arjun could hear it over the roar of the rain.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

The gears were grinding. The sound was wrong.

It was ticking backward.

"Time's up, gentlemen," Kaal Nath said.

The voice didn't come from a mouth. It emanated from the liquid metal itself, a deep, layered, synthetic baritone that vibrated the fillings in Arjun's teeth. It was a voice composed of a thousand different men who had begged for mercy and received order instead.

"The loop must be protected."

Kaal Nath stepped over the threshold.

The polished marble floor beneath his heavy, metallic foot instantly cracked, a spiderweb of fissures shooting out in every direction. The liquid metal of his leg shifted, absorbing the impact, reforming perfectly.

Arjun backed away. His right leg dragged. He couldn't breathe. The sheer, overwhelming pressure of the Enforcer's presence felt like standing at the bottom of the ocean.

Rishi didn't back away.

The ragged General drew his broken, rusted sword. The metal sang a dull, pathetic note.

"Rishi, don't," Arjun gasped, reaching out a trembling hand. "He'll erase you."

Rishi didn't look back. He rolled his shoulders, settling into a wide, perfectly balanced combat stance.

"I'm already a ghost, Doctor," Rishi said softly. He smiled. It was a terribly sad, fully human smile. "You can't kill what doesn't exist."

Behind Rishi, against the far, dark curve of the chamber wall, the air suddenly tore open.

It wasn't a door. It was a violent, jagged tear in the fabric of the room. A fissure of pure, swirling black energy. It crackled with negative light, pulling the dust and the smoke from the torch directly into its center.

"The rift," Rishi yelled over the deafening roar of the rain and the grinding of the backward-ticking watch. "The node is collapsing! Go! Jump into the final layer!"

"I'm not leaving you!" Arjun screamed, his voice cracking.

Kaal Nath raised the black tulwar. The liquid metal of his arm elongated, the muscles of mercury flexing with impossible tension.

"Whatever you do..." Rishi roared, charging forward, raising his broken blade against a god. "...do not trust The Oracle!"

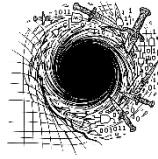
Kaal Nath brought the sword down.

Arjun didn't watch the impact. He couldn't.

He spun around, throwing himself desperately toward the swirling black tear in the wall. The suction of the rift grabbed him, a heavy, cold gravity that ripped at his clothes.

He squeezed his eyes shut and dove into the absolute dark.

CHAPTER 14



The Breach

The impact did not make a sound. It created a vacuum.

When Rishi's rusted, broken iron blade met the heavy, liquid-metal tulwar of the Enforcer, the air in the vast marble chamber simply ceased to exist. All ambient noise—the deafening roar of the 1965 monsoon pouring through the breached doorway, the hiss of the dying campfire, the ragged intake of Arjun's own breath—was violently sucked into a dead, pressurized void.

Arjun had thrown himself at the black tear in the wall. He expected to fall through empty space.

Instead, he hit the surface of the rift. It didn't yield. It felt like slamming face-first into a wall of freezing, half-cured tar. The gelatinous membrane of the vortex caught him,

sticking to his wet suit, suspending his body halfway off the marble floor.

He gasped, his lungs straining against the sudden lack of oxygen in the room. He peeled his face off the thick, black energy of the rift and twisted his neck to look over his shoulder.

The physics of the chamber were actively dying.

At the center of the room, Kaal Nath and Rishi were locked in a horrific, static-laced stalemate. The rusted iron of Rishi's sword was pressed hard against the smooth, shifting mercury of the Enforcer's blade.

Sparks didn't fly from the friction. Instead, jagged flakes of white noise—raw, unrendered digital static—sprayed outward from the crossed weapons. Where the static touched the floor, the polished marble instantly corrupted. The ancient stone turned a sickly, pixelated gray, completely losing its texture and depth.

"You are out of bounds," Kaal Nath's voice resonated.

The sound bypassed Arjun's ears completely. It vibrated directly inside his jawbone, a heavy, layered, synthetic baritone that tasted like battery acid.

"I've been out of bounds for four hundred years," Rishi

ground out.

The ragged General shifted his weight. His heavy boots dug into the cracking marble. He twisted his wrists, violently wrenching the rusted blade upward.

It was a perfect, brutal military parry. It should have disarmed the Enforcer entirely.

It didn't.

Kaal Nath didn't resist the parry. The liquid metal of his arm simply disconnected at the wrist.

Arjun watched, his eyes wide, his breath completely frozen in his chest. The Enforcer's hand—still tightly gripping the black tulwar—separated from the forearm, suspended in mid-air. In the same microsecond, the mercury of Kaal Nath's shoulder bulged outward, rapidly extruding a completely new arm, a new hand, and a new, razor-sharp blade.

The new tulwar slashed downward in a vicious, blinding arc.

Rishi threw himself backward. The tip of the liquid metal blade missed his throat by a fraction of an inch.

It hit the campfire instead.

The fire didn't scatter. It was deleted. The glowing orange embers, the charred wood, the thick gray smoke—the instant the black metal touched them, they winked out of existence. Not crushed. Not extinguished. Erased. Leaving a perfectly smooth, circular patch of absolute nothingness in the center of the floor.

"Arjun!" Rishi roared, stumbling back, his chest heaving. The sheer physical exertion was making the ghost sweat. Real, heavy drops of water sliding down his dirt-caked face. "Push through it! It's thick, but it gives! Push!"

Arjun gritted his teeth. He dug his ruined leather boots against the baseboard of the wall, using his legs to drive his body weight deeper into the freezing, viscous black energy of the rift. It felt like crawling through wet concrete. His shoulders burned. The cold was absolute, numbing his fingers until he couldn't feel the fabric of his own clothes.

"I can't," Arjun choked out. The air in the room rushed back in, hitting his lungs with a heavy, dusty weight. "It's stuck. It's rejecting the mass."

Kaal Nath turned his featureless, mirrored face toward the sound of Arjun's voice.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

The broken gold pocket watch embedded in the Enforcer's liquid chest plate ground loudly, ticking backward. The sound was escalating, growing faster, matching the accelerating collapse of the local node.

"The file cannot be transferred," Kaal Nath stated.

The Enforcer took a step toward Arjun. The heavy, metallic foot cracked the marble completely in half. The floor of the chamber tilted.

Gravity broke.

Arjun felt his stomach drop as the entire room shifted fifteen degrees to the left. The unlit brass oil lamps resting in the thousands of wall niches slid out, plummeting toward the floor. They didn't fall straight down. They fell in slow motion, arcing sideways, their brass casings twisting through the heavy, dust-choked air.

Rishi didn't lose his footing. He used the shifting gravity.

The General launched himself off a rising slab of broken marble. He vaulted through the air, completely horizontal, and slammed his heavy, booted feet directly into the center of Kaal Nath's liquid chest.

The impact was sickening.

Rishi's boots sank knee-deep into the heavy mercury. The Enforcer's body rippled violently, the smooth, mirrored surface distorting into chaotic, jagged waves.

Kaal Nath staggered backward, the heavy metal of his boots dragging a deep trench through the stone floor.

Rishi didn't pull his legs out. He leaned forward, gripping the hilt of his broken sword with both hands, and drove the rusted, jagged iron directly upward, burying it deep into the underside of Kaal Nath's featureless chin.

The blade sank all the way to the crossguard.

Arjun stopped struggling against the rift. He hung there, suspended in the black tar, watching the impossible execution.

"Did it," Rishi panted, his hands trembling violently on the hilt. He looked over his shoulder at Arjun. A wild, desperate grin broke through the dirt on his face. "Told you. Just have to hit the hardware."

Arjun's heart hammered a frantic, irregular rhythm. He wanted to believe it. He wanted to see the monster fall.

But Kaal Nath didn't fall.

The Enforcer reached up with his left hand. The liquid

metal fingers wrapped slowly, deliberately around the rusted iron blade embedded in his head.

"Local resistance noted," Kaal Nath's layered voice vibrated. It didn't come from a throat. It emanated from the entire mass of mercury. "Executing hard scrub."

The liquid metal fingers squeezed.

The thick, heavy iron of the rusted sword shattered. It didn't break into pieces; it turned instantly into a fine, gray ash that sifted through Kaal Nath's fingers and disappeared before it hit the floor.

Rishi's desperate smile vanished.

"No," Rishi whispered. He tried to pull his legs free from the Enforcer's chest.

The mercury hardened. It instantly shifted from a viscous liquid to solid, unyielding chrome, trapping Rishi's boots entirely.

Kaal Nath raised his right arm. The black tulwar elongated, thinning out into a long, wicked spike.

"Rishi!" Arjun screamed. He tore his left arm free from the black vortex, reaching out toward the center of the room. "Move!"

But the General couldn't move. He was anchored to the machine.

Kaal Nath drove the black spike directly through the center of Rishi Malhotra's chest.

There was no blood.

Arjun watched, his eyes wide and completely dry, as the point of the black spike emerged from between Rishi's shoulder blades.

Rishi's mouth opened in a silent, agonizing gasp. His amber eyes blew wide, the pupils expanding until they consumed the iris entirely. His hands flew up, desperately clutching the thick spike protruding from his sternum.

The deletion process didn't happen in an instant. It was slow. It was methodical.

It started at the wound. The dirty, gray fabric of Rishi's military tunic began to lose its texture. It flattened out, turning into a patch of two-dimensional grayscale static. The static began to spread, crawling outward like a necrosis.

"Arjun..." Rishi choked.

The voice was entirely wrong. The heavy, gravelly tone was completely stripped away. It sounded thin. Tinny. Like

a voice coming through a broken telephone speaker submerged in water.

The static reached his hands. The calluses, the dirt, the heavy scars earned in the Mughal courts—they all smoothed over, losing their physical geometry, becoming flat, gray noise.

"Arjun, look at me," Rishi stuttered. The right side of his face was beginning to pixelate. His jaw was locking up, the code failing to render the movement of the muscles.

Arjun hung in the rift, tears finally breaking free, cutting hot tracks through the cold sweat on his face. He shook his head. "I'm here. I'm here."

"Don't..." Rishi's voice dropped in pitch, a terrifying, dragging distortion. "Don't... hesitate. You have to... cut the lock."

The static crawled up his neck. It hit his remaining amber eye. The color drained out of it instantly, leaving a hollow, gray pixel in its place.

Kaal Nath didn't pull the spike out. The Enforcer simply stood there, serving as the conduit for the system's absolute authority, watching the anomaly disintegrate.

The entire chamber was falling apart around them.

The massive, spiraling mural on the wall—the ledger of Arjun’s past lives—began to weep. The ancient pigments liquefied. Thick streams of ochre, lapis, and blood-red paint ran violently down the curved stone, mixing together in a muddy, chaotic mess, completely destroying the images of the hanging officer, the bleeding scientist, the man with the dagger. The system was wiping the hard drive.

The 1965 monsoon roared louder, the yellow streetlamps from the dockyard bleeding violently into the cavernous room, mixing with the falling dust to create a sickly, suffocating fog.

Rishi was almost gone.

From the chest down, he was entirely converted to gray, hissing static. He didn't have legs anymore. He didn't have lungs. He was just a head and a left shoulder, fighting desperately to hold onto the final scrap of his existence.

"Tell her," Rishi rasped. The words were barely legible now. A faint, broken transmission. "Tell her... I didn't kneel."

Kaal Nath twisted the spike.

The remaining chunk of Rishi Malhotra—the last ghost of the Unbreaking Shield—shattered.

He exploded into a massive, blinding cloud of white noise. The sound of the static was deafening, a physical pressure that blew Arjun's hair back. The gray pixels hovered in the air for a single heartbeat, illuminated by the flashing lightning of the storm outside, before winking completely into nothingness.

He was gone. No body. No ash. No memory.

"Deletion complete," Kaal Nath stated.

The Enforcer withdrew the liquid metal spike. It shrank, reforming back into a heavy, perfectly balanced hand.

Kaal Nath turned slowly, his featureless, mirrored face locking onto Arjun.

The backward ticking of the watch was incredibly fast now. *Ticktickticktick*. It sounded like an insect frantically beating its wings against glass.

"Target zero-zero-one," Kaal Nath resonated, taking a heavy step toward the wall. "Prepare for formatting."

Arjun stared at the empty space where Rishi had been.

He felt a heavy, crushing emptiness in his own chest. He had known the man for less than an hour, but the loss felt profound. Ancient. It was the loss of the only other person

who understood the absolute terror of the cage.

You must find the one thing you fear most. And you have to choose it over her.

Arjun looked at the approaching Enforcer. He looked at the heavy, shifting mercury. He didn't feel pity for the mathematician trapped inside. He felt a cold, sharp, terrifying clarity.

If he died here, the loop reset. Aditi would wake up in the apartment. She would make coffee. She would smile at him. And the cage would remain perfectly locked for another lifetime.

"No," Arjun whispered.

He stopped trying to push his body *through* the freezing tar of the rift. He changed his tactic. He reached his free right hand deep into the black energy, digging his fingers in until he felt the bone-deep, burning cold of the absolute dark.

He didn't push. He pulled.

He grabbed the edge of the tear in reality, wrapping his hands around the frayed, crackling energy of the void, and hauled his entire body weight violently backward.

The gelatinous membrane stretched. It resisted, clinging stubbornly to the fabric of his ruined suit, trying to keep him anchored to the dying node.

Kaal Nath lunged.

The Enforcer covered twenty feet in a single, impossible blur of liquid motion. The mercury arm extended, the hand forming into a long, flat blade aimed directly at Arjun's throat.

Arjun screamed, throwing every ounce of strength he had left into his shoulders.

The membrane snapped.

The sound was like a massive rubber cable breaking underwater.

Arjun fell backward into the absolute dark.

He saw the blade of liquid metal pierce the space where his neck had been a microsecond before. He saw the cavernous marble chamber, the weeping paint of the mural, and the violent, yellow storm of the 1965 dockyard all shrinking rapidly into a tiny, distant square of light.

And then, the tear stitched itself shut.

The light vanished entirely.

Arjun tumbled weightlessly into the freezing, silent abyss
of the Zero Point.

ACT III:
ZERO POINT

CHAPTER 15



The Architecture of Heaven

The falling stopped, but there was no impact.

Arjun braced for the bone-snapping crunch of hitting solid ground. He squeezed his eyes shut, his hands flying up to protect his head. But the violent, freezing velocity of the black void simply bled away. Gravity didn't catch him; it slowly, gently inverted.

He didn't hit the floor. The floor caught him.

He rolled onto his side, his ruined charcoal suit slapping wetly against a perfectly smooth surface. He gasped, his lungs inflating violently. The air here was incredibly thin. It lacked the heavy, suffocating humidity of the Bombay docks and the ancient, dusty rot of the cursed chamber. It tasted sharp. Clinical. It smelled intensely of hot silicon, ozone, and a faint, sweet trace of crushed jasmine.

He opened his eyes.

He was lying on a mirror. Or something that functioned like one. The surface beneath his cheek was completely frictionless, a vast expanse of dark, polished glass that stretched out in every direction until it vanished into a hazy horizon.

He pushed himself up onto his hands and knees. A drop of muddy rainwater fell from the tip of his nose. It hit the glass. It didn't splash. It simply sat there, a dirty, brown smudge against a pristine reflection of infinity.

Arjun looked down into the floor.

He didn't see his own face staring back. He saw a galaxy. Thousands of tiny, brilliant white and violent violet stars spun slowly in the deep black of the reflection beneath his palms. He was kneeling on the surface of a dying nebula.

His right knee throbbed. A sharp, localized spike of human pain that tethered him to reality.

"Rishi," Arjun whispered.

The name didn't echo. It didn't bounce. The acoustics of the space swallowed the sound immediately, pulling the audio into the vacuum.

He grabbed the wet, heavy fabric of his slacks and dragged his bad leg forward, forcing himself to stand. His joints popped. His muscles, flooded with lactic acid and the residual shock of the timeline jumps, trembled violently.

He stood up and finally looked at the architecture of heaven.

It was a physical impossibility. A severe, terrifying juxtaposition of centuries and code.

Towering around him were massive, sweeping arches made of rough, dark red sandstone. They were deeply carved with the intricate, geometric floral patterns of the Mughal era. But the stone wasn't whole. Halfway up the curve of the arches, the red sandstone began to glitch. It didn't crumble. It smoothed out, melting directly into perfectly cylindrical pillars of liquid chrome.

The chrome pillars stretched upward, holding up a ceiling that didn't exist.

Instead of a dome or a sky, the arches framed a massive, swirling vortex of deep space. It mirrored the floor perfectly. The stars up there weren't twinkling. They were aggressively burning out, flaring into violent red giants before collapsing into pinpricks of dark matter.

Arjun took a step forward.

His leather boot clicked against the glass floor. *Clack*. He waited for the sound to carry. It didn't. The silence of the Zero Point was oppressive. It was the heavy, suffocating silence of an anechoic chamber. It made the blood rushing through his own ears sound like a roaring river.

He limped toward the nearest pillar. He needed to touch it. He needed a tactile confirmation that his mind hadn't completely fractured into a schizophrenic break in the Verma Institute lab.

He reached his hand out. His fingers brushed the red sandstone base.

It felt gritty. Warm. Ancient. He could feel the fine, powdery dust of the rock coating the ridges of his fingerprints.

He slid his hand upward, following the curve of the pillar to where the stone met the metal.

The transition was immediate and violent. One inch, his hand was resting on warm rock. The next, his palm slapped against freezing, utterly frictionless chrome. The metal was so cold it burned, sticking slightly to the sweat on his skin.

He jerked his hand back. He stared at his own palm, breathing heavily through his nose.

"Just code," he muttered, his voice a dry, pathetic rasp. He wiped his hand on his wet suit jacket. "It's all... it's a motherboard. A rendering."

But it didn't feel like a rendering. It felt terrifyingly permanent.

He turned away from the pillar and looked down the long, impossible nave of the temple.

The chrome and sandstone arches stretched forward in a perfectly straight line, forming a massive corridor that led toward a central point. The light here was strange. There was no sun. No oil lamps. The illumination seemed to bleed directly out of the chrome itself, casting a flat, shadowless, clinical glare over the entire expanse.

He started walking.

Every step sent a jolt of pain up his right leg. He favored his left, adopting a heavy, uneven limp.

Clack... drag. Clack... drag.

He walked for what felt like ten minutes. The geometry of the space refused to behave. He would fix his eyes on a sandstone arch fifty feet ahead, take five steps, and suddenly the arch was towering directly over him. Distance was a

suggestion here. Time was irrelevant. His broken pocket watch—if he had one—would have stopped completely.

His mind wandered in the dead quiet.

He thought of the heavy, rusted spike burying itself into Rishi's chest. He remembered the dirty gray static eating the General alive.

Tell her I didn't kneel.

Arjun swallowed hard, fighting down a sudden, violent surge of nausea. He stopped walking. He bent over, resting his hands on his knees, gasping for air that felt too thin to process.

His chest ached. The phantom scar from the Saffron storm throbbed, beating in time with his racing heart.

She is the lock on the door.

Rishi's words echoed in his skull, much louder than anything in the physical room.

Arjun squeezed his eyes shut. He saw the mural. He saw his own arm, raised high, gripping the jagged iron dagger. He saw the blade buried deep into the chest of the woman he loved.

"No," Arjun whispered. A tear broke loose, sliding down

his cheek, cutting a warm path through the cold sweat and grime. It dripped off his jaw and hit the glass floor. "No. Not Aditi. She... she burns the toast. She leaves the reading lamp on."

He opened his eyes. He stared at his blurry reflection in the starry floor.

He looked like a corpse. His skin was gray, pulled tight over his cheekbones. His hair was a matted, oily mess. His suit was torn, stained with rust, mud, and spilled coffee.

She is a subroutine designed to keep you asleep.

If Rishi was right... if his entire marriage, his apartment in Bandra, the smell of lavender shampoo, the quiet Sunday mornings... if all of it was just a custom-built sedative designed to prevent him from looking too closely at the math...

What was left?

If he removed Aditi from his core equation, there was nothing. Just a hollow, terrifying void.

"You have to choose it over her." Arjun repeated Rishi's final lesson out loud. The words felt like broken glass in his throat.

He forced himself to stand up straight. He wiped his face with the ruined sleeve of his jacket. He didn't know if he had the strength to hold the dagger. He didn't know if he could look at that face and choose the dark.

But he had to see the end of the code.

He started walking again.

The arches began to widen, opening up into a massive, circular epicenter.

Arjun limped past the final chrome pillar. He stopped.

The center of the Zero Point was entirely empty, save for one object.

Sitting directly in the middle of the glassy floor was an altar. It was a massive, rectangular slab of unpolished, pitch-black marble. It had no legs. It did not rest on the floor. It floated exactly two inches above the glass, humming with a frequency that Arjun didn't hear, but felt entirely in his dental work.

The nebula in the ceiling directly above the altar was different. The stars there weren't violet or white. They were a deep, angry, bruised red.

Arjun walked slowly toward the floating marble.

The air here felt thicker. The smell of hot silicon faded, completely overpowered by the heavy, suffocating scent of jasmine and rain.

He stopped ten feet from the altar.

Standing on the far side of the black marble, waiting for him, was a silhouette.

Arjun's breath hitched. He tried to speak, but his vocal cords seized. He stood in the absolute silence of the Zero Point, his wet suit dripping onto the stars beneath his feet, and stared at the architect of his infinite hell.

CHAPTER 16



The Warden

The silhouette moved.

It stepped away from the dark side of the floating black marble and into the flat, shadowless glare radiating from the chrome pillars.

Arjun stopped breathing. His lungs simply locked, refusing to draw in the thin, silicon-scented air.

She wore the same ancient, shifting robes from the Saffron storm. They were impossible to focus on directly. The fabric looked like it was woven from the dead space between constellations—a slow, swirling mass of dark matter and silver starlight that seemed to possess its own localized gravity.

But it wasn't the robes that paralyzed him.

It was the face.

The dark, heavy hair, parted slightly off-center. The exact slope of the cheekbones. The faint, almost imperceptible scar just above the left eyebrow from a childhood bicycle accident she had told him about on their third date.

It was Aditi.

"You made it further this time," she said.

Arjun flinched. The sound hit him like a physical strike to the sternum. It wasn't the layered, metallic baritone of Kaal Nath. It wasn't the cold, imperial resonance of the woman in the Saffron storm.

It was Aditi's voice. It was the exact pitch, the exact soft cadence she used when she woke him up on a Sunday morning to ask if he wanted coffee. It was warm. It was entirely human.

A hot, sour rush of bile hit the back of his throat. He doubled over, clamping a hand over his mouth. He dry-heaved, his empty stomach violently contracting. Nothing came up but a string of bitter, metallic saliva. He spat it onto the pristine glass floor. It smeared against the reflection of the dying red stars.

"Stop," Arjun choked out. He wiped his mouth with his ruined, dirt-caked sleeve. He didn't stand up straight. He stayed hunched, keeping his eyes fixed on the smudge of spit on the floor. "Don't use her voice."

"I am not using it, Arjun."

He heard the soft, fabric-rustle of her robes as she took a step closer. The heavy, cloying scent of jasmine washed over him, completely burying the smell of burnt ozone.

"Take it off," Arjun demanded, his voice cracking. He swallowed hard, the muscles in his neck tight and corded. He forced his eyes up, glaring at her feet. She was barefoot. Her toenails were painted the exact same pale pink Aditi had worn three days ago. "Just... take the template off. I know what you are. Rishi told me. Stop hiding."

"Rishi was a corrupted file," The Oracle said softly. "He spent four hundred years sitting in the dark, going mad from memory degradation. He didn't understand the architecture."

She rested her hand on the edge of the floating black altar. Her fingers were long. Delicate. Smooth.

"Look at me."

"No."

"Arjun. Please."

The 'please' broke him. The slight, desperate waver in the syllable.

He looked up.

She wasn't glaring at him. She didn't look angry. She looked at him with an expression of profound, crushing exhaustion. Her dark eyes were entirely bloodshot. She looked like a woman who had spent a hundred lifetimes watching the man she loved tear himself apart.

"I am not wearing a template," she said, her voice dropping to a heavy, tragic whisper. "This is the root directory. Aditi isn't a mask I put on to manipulate you in the real world. Aditi is me, rendered down into a mortal frame, wiped of all systemic authority, so that I could sit in the apartment with you and hold your hand."

Arjun's bad knee gave out.

He dropped hard onto the glass floor, the impact sending a jarring shock up his thigh. He didn't try to get up. He sat there, his wet, charcoal suit pooling around him in a miserable, filthy heap.

"Why?" Arjun asked. His voice was completely hollow. "If you are the Warden... if you control the loop... why

would you put yourself inside the cage with me?"

"Because the cage doesn't work if it's empty," she said simply.

She walked slowly around the floating marble altar. She didn't float. She walked exactly like Aditi. A slight drag on the left heel.

She stopped three feet in front of him.

"A prison made of iron bars and concrete is inefficient," The Oracle explained, looking down at him. "A consciousness as volatile as yours will always find the weakness in the physical geometry. You will break the walls. You will shatter the timeline. You will find the 0.04 percent variance."

She knelt. The starlight robes pooled on the glass floor, shifting and swirling like dark water. She reached out.

Arjun shrank back, pressing his shoulders against nothing.

Her hand stopped in the air between them. A microscopic flinch of hurt crossed her face. A perfectly human reaction. She slowly lowered her hand, resting it on her own knee.

"The only way to contain you," she continued, "is to use your own gravity against you. I had to build a world you wouldn't want to break. I gave you the Verma Institute. I gave you a career. And I gave you me. I became your anchor."

"You built a lie," Arjun spat, his hands balling into fists on his lap. He felt the cold smudge of sweat on his forehead. "You drugged me with a fake life so I wouldn't see the chains."

"I built a quarantine."

The Oracle's voice hardened. The soft, Aditi-cadence slipped for a fraction of a second, revealing the cold, ancient steel underneath.

She stood up. She raised her right hand and swept it in a slow, wide arc across the empty air of the Zero Point.

The clinical glare of the chrome pillars vanished. The massive sandstone arches dissolved.

The environment violently shifted.

Arjun wasn't kneeling on a glass floor anymore. He was floating in a vast, three-dimensional grid of pure, blinding white light. Massive rivers of complex, glowing code flowed all around him in perfect, harmonious lines. It was beautiful.

A flawless, silent mathematical equilibrium.

"This is the baseline," The Oracle's voice echoed from everywhere at once. "The uncorrupted universe. Everything in its place. A perfect, closed-loop equation."

Then, a black spot appeared in the white light.

It started small, a tiny speck of rotting, dark static. But it didn't stay small. It violently replicated.

The black static ate into the glowing lines of code, corrupting them instantly. The harmonious rivers of light began to violently tangle, knotting into ugly, chaotic snarls. The mathematical perfection began to shriek—a high-frequency, digital scream that made Arjun cover his ears.

"What is that?" Arjun yelled over the noise.

"That is you."

The Oracle materialized directly in front of him. She pointed at the rapidly expanding cancer of black static.

"You think you are a hero, Arjun," she said. Her eyes were completely dry. "You think you are a pioneer breaking through the false reality to find the truth. You aren't. You are a virus."

Arjun stared at the black rot eating the universe.

"I'm a man," he gasped, his chest heaving. "I'm human."

"You were," she corrected. "Eons ago. But somewhere in the cycle of life and death, your code hung. Your soul... or whatever primitive designation you prefer... refused to be formatted. You acquired a residual consciousness. You started remembering the past iterations."

She gestured to the tangled, dying code.

"When you remember, Arjun, you reject the script. You push back against the boundaries of physics. And when you push back, the fabric of reality tears."

The environment shifted again.

The white grid vanished. They were back in the Zero Point. The chrome pillars. The floating altar. The glass floor reflecting the dying red nebula.

Arjun was still on his knees. He felt sick. The heavy, suffocating drag of the air in his lungs felt totally inadequate.

"You aren't a savior," The Oracle said, looking down at him. "You are an existential threat. If you break the loop... if you force your way out of this localized quarantine zone... your consciousness will bleed into the primary mainframe."

You will tear the universe apart. Literally. 'The stars will simply cease to render.'

Arjun stared at the glassy floor. He saw the red stars spinning beneath his reflection.

I am a virus.

He thought of his frantic calculations in the lab. The obsession that drove him to push the Ananta Device past its limits. He thought he was discovering a new dimension. He was just a tumor trying to metastasize.

"So that's it?" Arjun whispered. He looked up at her face. The face of his wife. "The Kaal Nath deletion... it's just a white blood cell."

"Kaal Nath cleans the local nodes," she nodded slowly. "He scrubs the physical environments you corrupt. The 1965 dockyard. The Mughal palace. But he cannot delete your core file. Only I can contain that."

She walked back to the floating black altar. She ran her fingertips along the edge of the smooth stone.

"The cycle doesn't exist to punish you, Arjun," she said, her voice dropping back into that heartbreaking, familiar softness. "It exists to protect everything else from you. And to protect you from the void."

"By trapping me in a lie," he rasped.

"By giving you peace." She turned around. "I give you a life, Arjun. I give you prestige. I give you love. Real love. The Aditi you hold in your arms isn't faking it. She doesn't know she is a subroutine. She loves you completely. Isn't that enough?"

Arjun forced his right leg up. His knee screamed. He planted his boot on the glass and pushed himself upright. He stood awkwardly, listing slightly to the left.

"It's fake," Arjun said. He wiped his nose. His hand came away stained with a mixture of dirt and dried blood from his jaw. "If she doesn't have a choice to love me, it's not real. It's just a script executing."

"Free will is a mathematical illusion," The Oracle countered smoothly. "Chemical reactions in a biological brain. Or subroutines in a digital architecture. The output is exactly the same. The warmth of her hand feels identical either way."

"It's not the same."

"It is."

"Stop!" Arjun yelled. The word tore his throat.

He limped forward. He closed the distance, stopping inches from the floating marble. She was right across from him.

"Rishi told me," Arjun said, breathing heavily. He stared directly into her dark, bloodshot eyes. "He told me about the first time. The origin."

The Oracle's expression completely froze.

The micro-movements of her face—the slight twitch of her eyebrow, the natural parting of her lips—ceased entirely. She became a statue.

"He told you a corrupted fairy tale," she stated. The voice was totally flat. Dead.

"He told me I killed you," Arjun pushed. His heart hammered against his ribs. He was poking the bear. He was prodding the administrator of the universe. "Before the loop. Before the cage. I realized what you were doing, and I drove a dagger into your chest."

"You did no such thing."

"Then why did you look like that?" Arjun demanded. He leaned over the black altar. "In the mural! Why did you look so sad while I was killing you?"

The Oracle didn't answer. She stared at him. The air pressure in the Zero Point spiked rapidly, popping Arjun's ears. The red stars in the reflection beneath them began to spin violently faster.

"Because I hesitated," Arjun answered for her. His voice dropped to a harsh whisper. "I looked at your face, and I hesitated. I couldn't finish it. And in that one second, you trapped me."

"I saved you."

"You weaponized my own humanity against me!" Arjun roared. He slammed both of his hands down onto the floating black marble.

The altar did not move. It absorbed the impact perfectly.

"You made yourself the lock!" Arjun spat, leaning across the stone. "You knew I could break the physics. You knew I could outrun Kaal Nath. But you knew I could never, ever kill my own wife."

The Oracle looked down at his hands resting on the altar.

Slowly, she reached out and placed her warm, smooth hands directly over his cold, filthy ones.

Arjun flinched, but he didn't pull away. The physical

contact was agonizing. It was the exact same soft, firm grip Aditi used when she tried to calm him down after a nightmare.

"I am the lock," The Oracle whispered. She leaned forward, her face inches from his. He could smell the jasmine. He could see the microscopic pores in her skin. It was flawlessly, terrifyingly real. "And I am offering you the key, Arjun. Put it down."

"Put what down?"

"The glitch." She squeezed his hands. "Stop fighting. Stop looking at the math. Let the system run the reset protocol."

Arjun stared at her. "You want me to go to sleep."

"I want you to live," she pleaded. A single tear escaped her right eye, sliding down her cheek. "If you surrender now... the timeline repairs. You wake up in the apartment in Bandra. The monsoon is raining outside. I am making coffee. You don't remember the Mughal palace. You don't remember Kaal Nath. You just remember us."

Arjun's chest tightened. A heavy, suffocating physical ache.

He pictured it. The yellow reading lamp. The smell of the

roasting espresso beans. The absolute, quiet safety of being oblivious. He was so tired. His bones ached. His mind was fractured, bleeding out across four centuries of corrupted data. All he had to do was say yes, and the pain would end. The noise would stop.

"And Rishi?" Arjun asked softly. "What happens to the Echoes?"

The Oracle didn't blink. "They are purged. The hard drive is wiped clean. A perfect slate."

Arjun looked down at her hands covering his.

If you hesitate, he will erase you. You will never have been born.

He thought of the gray static eating Rishi alive. The Unbreaking Shield, reduced to a screaming digital error because he refused to surrender his grief.

Arjun slowly pulled his hands out from under hers.

He stepped back from the altar. The cold air of the Zero Point rushed in to fill the space between them.

"I can't," Arjun said.

The Oracle's hands hovered over the black marble. The tear on her cheek evaporated instantly.

"Arjun," she warned. The tone shifted. The soft, loving wife was gone. The Warden returned.

"I can't," Arjun repeated, his voice gaining strength. He stood up straight, ignoring the screaming pain in his knee. "I am a scientist. I observe the data. I quantify the variables."

He pointed a shaking finger at her face.

"And the data says that the world you are offering me is a cemetery. It's a perfectly peaceful, perfectly quiet graveyard built on top of deleted souls."

The Oracle's face hardened into a mask of pure, unyielding stone.

"Then you leave me no choice," she said.

She raised both of her hands high above her head. The starlight fabric of her robes flared, catching an invisible wind.

The architecture of heaven began to scream.

CHAPTER 17



The Illusion of Choice

The audio file ended.

The silence that followed wasn't just the absence of Arjun's recorded voice. It was a heavy, physical vacuum that pressed against Aditi's eardrums, thick and suffocating.

She sat completely motionless in his heavy leather chair. The cold foam padding offered no comfort. She stared blindly at the bright blue monitor. The waveform of his voice was a flat, dead line across the screen.

She doesn't know she is a subroutine. She is a subroutine. Aditi raised her right hand. Her fingers were trembling. A fine, violent, uncontrollable vibration. She brought her hand to her opposite forearm and pinched the skin. Hard.

Her nails dug into the flesh until it burned. A sharp,

localized spike of pain. She let go. A tiny, red crescent moon indented the skin, slowly filling with the warm rush of blood.

It hurt. It felt completely, undeniably real.

"I'm here," she whispered to the empty lab. Her voice sounded thin, scratching against her dry throat. "I have a heartbeat. I have a mother in Pune. I broke my collarbone when I was ten."

She swallowed hard, the muscles in her neck tight and aching. She tasted old, bitter coffee and the metallic tang of adrenaline.

She looked away from her arm, staring past the glare of the monitor. The massive brass and chrome iris of the Ananta Device sat dead in the center of the room.

Then, the pen dropped.

It was a cheap, blue ballpoint Arjun had left near the edge of the mahogany desk. Aditi watched it roll. It hit the edge of the wood. But it didn't hit the obsidian floor.

It fell straight through the solid desk.

There was no sound of plastic striking wood. There was no clatter on the floor tiles. The pen simply clipped through

the mahogany top, passing through the solid matter as if it were entirely holographic, and vanished into the dark space beneath the desk.

Aditi stopped breathing.

She leaned forward, her chest pressing against the hard edge of the desk. She looked down. The floor beneath the chair was completely empty. No pen.

A cold, crawling sensation started at the base of her spine. It moved upward, raising the tiny hairs on her arms. The air in the lab suddenly felt highly charged, thick with the sharp, acidic smell of static electricity and burning copper.

Pop. One of the overhead LED spots flared blindingly white, then snapped off.

Aditi stood up. The leather chair scraped backward, the sound excessively loud.

She looked toward the reinforced glass walls of the Institute. Outside, the Mumbai monsoon was still raging. But the rain was wrong.

The water droplets hitting the thick polymer pane weren't sliding down the glass. They were freezing in place. Hundreds of thousands of tiny, distorted gray beads of water hung suspended mid-air, defying gravity. The heavy,

low-frequency rumble of the storm outside began to stutter. It caught on a single audio frame, looping violently.

Rrr-rrr-rrr-rrr.

The system was crashing.

"Arjun," Aditi breathed. She backed away from the desk.

The automatic double doors of the lab hissed.

The sound was slow, dragging, as if the mechanical motor fighting to open the glass was submerged in thick mud. The doors parted.

Dr. Rao walked in.

He wore his usual beige cardigan and wire-rimmed glasses. He held a wet, black umbrella in his right hand.

"Aditi," Dr. Rao said. His voice was perfectly calm. Clinically soothing.

She took another step back, her boots squeaking on the polished floor. She stared at him. Something was fundamentally broken about the way he occupied the space. The harsh overhead lights cast a shadow behind him, but the shadow was facing the wrong direction. It stretched toward the light source, rather than away from it.

"You didn't stay on the couch," Rao said gently. He closed the umbrella. A pool of water collected around his brown loafers. "I told you to wait for me."

"How did you get up here?" Aditi asked. Her chest heaved. The air felt incredibly thin, as if the oxygen was being rapidly vented from the room. "The elevators require biometric clearance after midnight."

Rao smiled. It was a polite, entirely hollow expression. The muscles around his eyes didn't contract.

"You are experiencing a severe dissociative episode, Aditi," he said, taking a slow step forward. "The trauma of the anniversary. You've broken into a restricted area. You are looking at files that don't make sense because your mind is actively looking for a conspiracy to explain a simple car crash."

"Stop lying," Aditi snapped. She pointed a trembling finger at the reinforced glass. "Look at the rain! The water is frozen. The physics are failing."

Rao didn't look at the window. He kept his eyes locked perfectly on her face.

"I see a storm," he said smoothly. "You see a symptom of your lithium deficiency."

"I don't take lithium!" she yelled. The sheer volume of her own voice startled her. She grabbed the edge of a server rack to steady herself. The metal casing was violently vibrating, humming with a frantic, desperate energy.

"Aditi, listen to me," Rao said. He stopped walking. He lowered the umbrella. "The police just called my cell phone."

Aditi froze.

"They found him," Rao said. The gentle, psychiatric tone deepened, gaining a heavy, comforting warmth. "Arjun. He didn't die on the Sea Link. He survived. He had amnesia. He's been living in a shelter in Navi Mumbai. They just identified his fingerprints."

The words hit her like a physical blow to the stomach.

A massive, overwhelming wave of pure, unadulterated relief washed over her, so strong it made her knees buckle. *He's alive. He's coming home.* She pictured his face. She pictured him walking through the door of their apartment, confused, tired, but real.

She took a step toward Rao.

But then she smelled it.

The heavy, cloying scent of crushed jasmine. It rolled off Dr. Rao in thick, invisible waves, completely overpowering the burning ozone of the failing servers.

I am the ending.

Aditi stopped. The relief vanished, instantly replaced by a cold, sharp, terrifying clarity.

"You're not Dr. Rao," she whispered.

The man in the beige cardigan tilted his head. The movement was slightly jerky. A dropped frame.

"He is on his way to your apartment right now," the thing wearing Rao's face insisted. The voice began to layer, gaining a faint, metallic rasp underneath the soothing tone. "You just need to go home, Aditi. You need to step away from the terminal. You need to accept the narrative."

Aditi looked past him, toward the primary monitor on Arjun's desk.

The screen had changed. The audio file was gone. In its place, a massive, blinking command prompt dominated the blue light.

SYSTEM COMPROMISED. ANOMALY
REACHING ZERO POINT.

EXECUTE HARD RESET? [Y/N]

"If I go home," Aditi said, her voice shaking violently. She looked back at Rao. "If I accept the narrative... what happens to him?"

"He lives," Rao said. The metallic layering in his voice was undeniable now. The beige cardigan began to desaturate, turning a flat, digital gray. "He forgets the math. He forgets the machine. He lives a long, quiet, happy life with the woman he loves."

"Trapped," Aditi said.

"Safe," the system corrected.

The lab shuddered. A massive, tectonic groan reverberated through the obsidian floor. A jagged black crack split the ceiling above the Ananta Device, raining fine white plaster dust down onto the brass iris.

Arjun was tearing the universe apart from the inside. He was fighting the Warden.

"He is destroying the environment," the Rao-program stated, its voice losing all human inflection. "If he proceeds, the local node will collapse. You will cease to execute. Press 'Y', Aditi. Save your husband. Save yourself."

Aditi stared at the blinking cursor on the screen.

EXECUTE HARD RESET.

It was the ultimate illusion of choice. The system didn't just need Arjun to submit; it needed the anchor to hold. It needed her to pull him back from the edge. It was weaponizing her love, turning her desperate, human need to see him again into the very iron bars of his cage.

She walked toward the desk.

The Rao-program watched her, perfectly still.

She placed her hands on the cold, hard plastic of the keyboard. Her fingers hovered over the 'Y' key.

She closed her eyes.

She remembered the way Arjun looked at her when he was tired. The heavy, dark circles under his eyes. The way he would rub his thumb over her knuckles when they sat on the couch in silence. Was it code? Was it just a subroutine executing perfectly to keep the anomaly docile?

It doesn't matter, she realized. A hot tear slipped down her cheek, splashing onto the spacebar. It's real to me. My love for him is real.

If she pressed the key, he would come home. They would drink tea. They would grow old in a world that was fundamentally, mathematically false. He would be safe, and he would be a prisoner forever.

If she loved him—truly loved him, not as a programmed anchor, but as a woman making a choice—she couldn't be his cage.

"I love him," Aditi whispered to the empty, dying room.

She opened her eyes.

She moved her finger.

She pressed 'N'.

ENTER.

The monitor immediately went black.

The silence that followed was absolute.

"Choice logged," the Rao-program said.

Aditi turned around.

Dr. Rao was gone. The glass doors were gone.

The dissolution of 2026 was not loud. It didn't explode. It was a quiet, terrifying unweaving.

The obsidian floor beneath her boots began to break apart into perfectly white, glowing polygons. The server racks lining the walls dissolved into rivers of raw, hissing static, drifting upward toward the cracked ceiling. The frozen raindrops on the window lost their shape, reverting to basic lines of green binary code before winking out completely.

Aditi didn't run. There was nowhere to run. The edge of the map was right here.

She stood in the center of the collapsing laboratory. The cold was biting now, the absolute zero of the void bleeding through the dying environment.

She looked down at her own hands.

The tips of her fingers were beginning to pixelate. The skin tone flattened, turning a dull, digital gray. The static crawled up her wrists, painless but entirely numbing. The sensation of the cold air, the smell of the ozone, the heavy, dragging weight of her own body—it was all being systematically scrubbed from the active memory.

"Arjun," she murmured. Her voice lacked audio. The sound simply failed to render.

She closed her eyes, holding onto the memory of his face for one final, perfect microsecond.

And then, the subroutine terminated.

CHAPTER 18



The Three Rifts

The scream did not come from the Oracle's throat. It came from the geometry of the room.

A high, metallic shrieking tore through the vacuum of the Zero Point. The massive, perfect cylinders of liquid chrome flanking the floating altar began to violently twist. They didn't bend like metal under heat; they warped like a corrupted image file being dragged across a screen. The smooth chrome bubbled, developing jagged, pixelated tumors of raw static.

Arjun dropped to the glass floor. He clamped both hands over his ears. It didn't help. The noise wasn't acoustic. It was structural. It bypassed his eardrums and vibrated directly into the fluid of his spine.

He squeezed his eyes shut, his forehead pressed against the freezing, mirror-like surface. The red stars beneath the

glass were spinning completely out of control, a chaotic, nauseating blur of dying light.

Crack.

A deep, tectonic fissure split the glass inches from his nose. A jagged line of absolute blackness opened in the floor.

The Oracle staggered.

She didn't glide. She didn't possess the terrifying, imperial grace she had carried just moments ago. She stumbled backward, her bare heel catching the edge of her starlight robes. She threw a hand out, bracing her palm against the floating black marble of the altar to keep from falling.

Arjun looked up. His breath came in shallow, ragged pulls. The air tasted burnt. Sour.

The Oracle was staring at her own left hand.

The tips of her fingers were turning gray. The soft, perfectly rendered skin of Aditi's template was flattening, losing its depth and warmth. It was the exact same desaturated, hissing static that had eaten Rishi Malhotra alive.

She inhaled a sharp, jagged breath. A deeply human

sound of shock.

"She let you go," the Oracle whispered.

The voice was entirely Aditi's. It was thick with tears. It was the sound of a woman standing in an empty apartment, staring at a blinking cursor on a dead monitor.

Arjun dragged his ruined body upward. His right knee was practically useless now, the joint swollen tight against the wet wool of his slacks. He braced his hands on his thighs, his chest heaving, fighting a wave of aggressive nausea.

"What did you do?" Arjun rasped. He coughed, a wet splatter of saliva and dirt hitting the cracked glass.

"I didn't do anything," the Oracle said. She lowered her gray, glitching hand. She looked at him. The profound, ancient sorrow in her dark eyes was entirely gone. It was replaced by a cold, raw panic. "She pressed 'No'."

Arjun froze.

"Aditi," he breathed.

"She rejected the reset protocol," the Oracle stated, her voice dropping into a flat, mechanical cadence as the template struggled to maintain its integrity. "She chose to terminate the subroutine rather than execute the quarantine."

'The anchor is gone. The local node is collapsing.'

The massive red sandstone arches above them detonated.

There was no fire. No explosion of rock. The ancient, carved stone simply ceased to render. Huge, cubic chunks of the architecture vanished into thin air, leaving jagged, bleeding edges of raw code exposed to the freezing void.

"Then the loop is broken," Arjun said. He wiped the cold sweat from his eyes. His hand was shaking. A frantic, exhausted tremor. "It's over."

"It is never over."

The Oracle stood up straight. The panic in her eyes hardened into absolute, unyielding administrative authority.

"If the anchor fails, the system executes the final failsafe," she said.

She raised both of her arms. The starlight fabric of her robes whipped violently around her, caught in a heavy, unnatural updraft. The smell of crushed jasmine vanished, instantly replaced by the sharp, metallic bite of melting copper and hot silicon.

"You have broken the rules, Arjun," her voice boomed.

The Aditi-cadence was entirely stripped away now. It was the layered, synthetic roar of a failing god. "Now, you must face the consequences."

She pulled her hands sharply apart.

The air directly behind the floating black altar tore open.

It was a physical, sickening sound. Like heavy, wet canvas being ripped violently down the middle.

Three massive, vertical tears appeared in the fabric of the Zero Point. They hovered ten feet in the air, stretching from the glass floor up into the dying red nebula above. They did not bleed static. They were windows. Three distinct, terrifying holes punched directly through the baseline code of the universe.

The sheer atmospheric pressure bleeding out of the rifts hit Arjun like a solid wall. He stumbled backward, his bad leg giving out. He fell hard onto his left hip, his hands frantically scraping against the cracked glass to stop himself from sliding.

He stared at the tears.

"Compliance," the Oracle announced. Her voice vibrated the broken chrome pillars. She pointed her glitching, gray hand toward the tear on the far left.

THE WHITE RIFT.

The light pouring out of the first tear was blindingly soft. It wasn't the clinical, eighteen-degree blue of the Verma Institute. It was the warm, golden glow of a Sunday morning.

Arjun squinted against the glare. The air bleeding from the white tear washed over his face.

It was warm. It smelled of roasting espresso beans, damp earth, and the distinct, comforting scent of lavender shampoo.

He saw movement inside the light. A kitchen. The granite countertops of his apartment in Bandra. The rain was gently, rhythmically tapping against the windowpane. Safe. Distant. And standing by the stove, holding two ceramic mugs, was Aditi.

She wasn't glitching. She wasn't wearing robes of starlight. She was wearing his oversized gray university t-shirt. She looked over her shoulder, directly out of the rift, and smiled.

Come back to bed, he heard her say. The audio was perfect. Clear.

"The cycle continues," the Oracle whispered, her voice

softening, weaponizing the warmth of the vision. "A seamless patch. You step through, and the memory of this room wipes entirely. You get the Nobel Prize. You get the quiet life. You get her. No scars. No static."

Arjun's chest tightened. A heavy, physical ache gripped his heart.

He wanted it. God, he wanted it so badly his teeth ached. He could physically feel the phantom warmth of that coffee mug in his cold, filthy hands. He could feel the soft cotton of her shirt. It was right there. One step, and the nightmare of the last four hundred years would vanish into a dream he would never quite remember.

He swallowed hard. He forced his eyes away from the kitchen.

He looked at the tear in the center.

THE RED RIFT.

The heat radiating from the middle tear was aggressive. Baking. It smelled of sulfur, burning hair, and melting plastic.

There was no kitchen in the red rift. There was only a chaotic, violent maelstrom of failing architecture. He saw the modern skyline of Mumbai collapsing, the glass

skyscrapers bending and twisting into impossible geometric shapes before shattering into raw binary code. He saw the Saffron battlefield, the war elephants burning alive, their flesh turning into screaming red static.

"The Break," the Oracle warned. Her layered voice trembled with a genuine, systemic dread. "You refuse the reset, but you refuse the quarantine. The virus metastasizes. The universe collapses. Everything you have ever observed, every soul trapped in the registry, burns out in a cascade failure."

Arjun dragged his eyes away from the fire. His skin felt baked, tight across his cheekbones.

He looked at the final tear on the far right.

THE BLACK RIFT.

There was no light. There was no heat. There was no smell.

It was a vertical scar of absolute, terrifying nothingness. It didn't reflect the red stars. It didn't reflect the chrome pillars. It was a void so dense and complete that it seemed to be actively sucking the visual data out of Arjun's retinas.

It was exactly like the void he had floated in before Rishi found him, but infinitely heavier.

"And that?" Arjun rasped, his voice a dry, pathetic scrape against the roaring noise of the collapsing room. He pointed a trembling, dirt-caked finger at the black tear. "What is that?"

The Oracle flinched. She physically recoiled from the black rift, taking a step closer to the floating altar to put solid matter between herself and the dark.

"That is not a choice," the Oracle said. Her Aditi-face twitched, a violent spasm of the cheek muscle. "That is the Void. The Unwritten."

"Where does it go?"

"Nowhere," she snapped. The panic was bleeding back into her voice. "It is the space outside the operating system. It is unrendered. Uncompiled. No physical laws. No time. No one who enters has ever returned. It is extinction."

Arjun stared into the black.

He felt a profound, heavy gravity pulling at his chest. It wasn't the physical suction of the rift. It was something deeper. A strange, terrifying resonance.

"You have two choices, Arjun," the Oracle demanded, stepping in front of the rifts, trying to block his line of sight to the dark. "Compliance, or the destruction of the grid."

Arjun looked at her.

Half of her face was flat gray static now. The Aditi-template was failing rapidly, peeling away to reveal a blank, featureless expanse of raw light underneath. The illusion was dying.

He looked back at the White Rift.

Aditi was still smiling in the kitchen. The espresso machine hissed.

If you surrender now... the timeline repairs.

He looked down at his own hands. They were coated in a thick, dark mixture of 1965 dockyard mud, the ancient dust of the cursed chamber, and his own dried blood. They were the hands of a man who had fought through hell to find the edge of the map.

"Rishi said you use my gravity against me," Arjun whispered.

He didn't speak loud enough to be heard over the groaning chrome pillars. He was talking to himself. A final, desperate calculation.

"He said you give me the one thing I can't bear to lose."

Arjun looked at the smiling, perfect projection of his

wife.

He loved her. He loved her with an intensity that defied the physics he had spent his life studying. But the woman in the White Rift wasn't the woman who had pressed 'No'. The woman who pressed 'No' had chosen to terminate her own existence so he could be free.

If he stepped into the White Rift, he was insulting her sacrifice. He was choosing the sedative over the reality she had died to give him.

He slowly pushed himself up.

His bad knee popped, a loud, wet sound. He ignored the flare of agony. He stood up entirely straight. His ruined charcoal suit hung heavily on his frame, dripping muddy water onto the cracked glass floor.

He looked at the Oracle.

"You think my greatest fear is losing her," Arjun said. His voice was steady now. The frantic, exhausted tremor in his vocal cords vanished, replaced by a cold, sharp absolute.

The Oracle stopped glitching for a microsecond. She stared at him, the single, perfect dark eye of the remaining Aditi-template widening.

"Arjun," she warned. "Do not."

"I thought it was, too," Arjun continued, taking a slow, limping step toward the floating black altar. "I thought I was afraid of the pain. I thought I was afraid of the static. I thought I was afraid of dying on that Saffron battlefield."

He took another step. The heat from the Red Rift baked the left side of his face. The smell of lavender from the White Rift pulled at his right.

"But I'm not."

He stopped directly in front of the Oracle. He was close enough to see the jagged, chaotic edges of the gray pixels eating away her jawline. He was close enough to smell the ozone burning underneath the jasmine.

"I remember the taste of the poisoned wine," Arjun whispered, his eyes locked on hers. "I remember the smell of burning horsehair. I remember the sound of Rishi's voice when Kaal Nath drove a spike through his chest."

Arjun reached up and touched his own sternum. Right over his heart. Right over the phantom scar.

"It hurts," Arjun said, his eyes welling with hot, sudden tears. "It hurts so much it makes me want to rip my own brain out. But it happened."

He dropped his hand.

"My fear isn't dying, Oracle," Arjun said.

He turned his head slowly, looking past her, entirely ignoring the warm, golden light of the kitchen and the screaming fire of the red destruction.

He locked his eyes directly onto the absolute, terrifying nothingness of the Black Rift.

"My fear is forgetting."

The Oracle gasped. It was a mechanical, ragged sound of a system crashing.

"If I take the White Rift, I forget Rishi," Arjun said, his voice dropping to a heavy, final tone. "I forget the Echoes. I forget the truth. I let you wipe the hard drive, and I go back to sleep in the cemetery."

He looked back at her.

"I'd rather be awake in the dark."

"You will cease to exist!" the Oracle shrieked. Her voice fractured into a dozen different overlapping frequencies, the sound shattering the remaining glass floor around the altar. "It is the void! There is no code! There is no memory!"

"Because no one has ever tried to write one," a rough, gravelly voice echoed.

Arjun flinched, his head snapping toward the sound.

Standing near the crumbling ruins of a red sandstone arch, untouched by the shifting gravity and the failing light, was a figure.

It was Kaal Nath.

But he wasn't shifting. The liquid mercury had stabilized, hardening into a dull, matte-black armor. He held the gold pocket watch in his hand. The glass face was shattered. The hands were completely still.

The Enforcer wasn't raising a weapon. He wasn't moving to attack. He was simply watching.

"He's right, Oracle," Kaal Nath resonated, the layered, metallic voices inside him finally quiet, reduced to a single, exhausted baritone. "Maybe it's time to see what's outside the book."

The Enforcer lowered the watch, letting it drop. It hit the glass floor and shattered into a cloud of gray pixels. Kaal Nath crossed his arms over his chest, standing perfectly still, a monument to a broken system. He was choosing to observe the failure.

Arjun looked at the Enforcer. Then, he looked at the Black Rift. The cold radiating from the void was absolute. It promised nothing. No peace. No pain. No gravity. No memory.

It was the terrifying, beautiful canvas of a completely blank page.

"Arjun, no!" the Oracle screamed.

She lunged forward, reaching out with her one remaining human hand, desperately trying to grab the lapel of his ruined suit. To anchor him. To hold him back.

But Arjun was already moving.

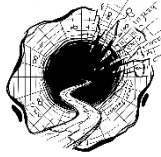
He didn't hesitate. He didn't look back at the warm light of the kitchen. He didn't look at the face of his wife.

He stepped past the floating black altar. He raised his foot, the ruined leather of his shoe crossing the threshold of the unrendered void.

He stepped into the Black Rift.

The darkness swallowed him whole.

CHAPTER 19



The Unwritten Dark

The transition was not instantaneous. It did not happen in a clean, cinematic flash.

It was agonizingly physical. Thick. Resistant. The Black Rift did not pull Arjun in; it required him to push his way through the absolute boundary of the rendering engine.

His right boot crossed the threshold.

The sensory feedback cut off with a violent, terrifying snap. He looked down. His right leg, from the knee down, simply ceased to exist. There was no pain. No blood. No bone. The ruined leather of his shoe, the soaked wool of his 1965 trousers, the mud from the Bombay docks—they weren't destroyed. They were un-compiled. They passed beyond the edge of the operating system and lost their geometric properties entirely.

He couldn't feel the floor. He felt the exact temperature of nothing.

Arjun gasped, a sharp, ragged intake of air that burned his dry throat. Human instinct—millions of years of biological programming—screamed at him to pull back. His brain fired frantic, panicked signals, demanding he retreat from the amputation of his own mass.

He didn't pull back. He shifted his weight, leaning his shoulders into the void.

Behind him, the Zero Point was tearing itself to pieces.

The Oracle dropped to her knees. The impact against the cracked glass floor was brutally heavy. She didn't bleed red. Where the sharp edges of the fractured mirror bit into the skin of her shins, she bled raw, blinding white light.

"Arjun!"

The scream was horrific. The Aditi-template was failing rapidly, unable to maintain cohesion as the local node crashed. Her voice skipped, a jagged, mechanical stutter overlapping with the frantic, tearing sound of the crumbling red sandstone arches.

"You're... you're killing it!" she shrieked. She dragged herself forward on her hands and knees, reaching

desperately toward his back. "You're killing... us!"

Arjun stopped. He stood with half of his body submerged in the unwritten dark, his left hand gripping the crackling, frayed edge of the rift.

He looked over his shoulder.

The sky was falling. The massive, swirling red nebula above them cracked exactly like cheap, heavy glass. Huge, jagged shards of the dying universe broke loose, plummeting toward the floor. As they fell, the stars inside them stretched into long, meaningless lines of green and white binary code, dissolving into hissing static before they even hit the ground.

"I'm not killing you," Arjun rasped. His chest heaved. The phantom scar on his sternum throbbed, a final, desperate flare of programmed agony. "I'm... I'm waking up."

He looked past her dragging, glitching form.

Standing near the base of a shattered chrome pillar, Kaal Nath watched the sky fall.

The Enforcer made no move to stop Arjun. He made no move to protect the Oracle. The heavy, shifting liquid mercury of his armor had completely stabilized, turning into

a dull, dry, matte-black shell. He looked exactly like a cast-iron statue left out in the rain for a century.

Kaal Nath looked at Arjun.

The featureless, mirrored face tilted slightly. A microscopic nod. An acknowledgment from the mathematician trapped inside the machine.

"Zero state," Kaal Nath resonated. The layered, terrifying baritone was gone. The voice was quiet. Singular. Exhausted.

The Enforcer let go of the black tulwar. The heavy weapon hit the glass floor and immediately exploded into a cloud of gray, pixelated ash.

Kaal Nath didn't fight the collapse. He welcomed the end of the noise. The matte-black armor flaked away, peeling off in thick, dry sheets of static. The heavy chest plate crumbled. The arms dissolved. In less than three seconds, the Enforcer was reduced to a small, unremarkable pile of gray dust on the mirror floor.

He was gone.

"Arjun... please."

The Oracle was three feet away. Her hand reached for

the muddy hem of his suit jacket. Half of her face was a sliding, chaotic mess of geometric polygons, but her left eye—Aditi's eye—was perfectly rendered. It was wide, terrified, and brimming with a single, flawless tear.

Arjun's throat tightened so hard he couldn't swallow. He looked at that eye. He felt the heavy, crushing gravity of the lock. He wanted to pull her through. He wanted to grab her hand and drag her into the dark with him.

She is a subroutine. He closed his eyes.

"Goodbye," Arjun whispered.

He pulled his left hand off the edge of the rift. He shifted his weight entirely into the void, pulling his remaining leg across the threshold.

The tear stitched itself shut.

It zipped downward with the sickening, wet sound of a heavy zipper closing on a body bag.

For a fraction of a microsecond, a thin, vertical sliver of light remained. Through it, Arjun saw the floating black altar drop out of the air, smashing violently through the glass floor. He saw the Oracle disintegrate entirely into a massive, blinding flash of white code.

And then, the universe pulled the plug.

The sliver vanished.

Absolute black. Absolute quiet.

Arjun did not fall. He did not float. The concepts of gravity, momentum, and direction required an environment to exist. Here, there was no environment. There was only the Unwritten.

He tried to open his eyes. They were already open. There was simply nothing for the optic nerve to process. He tried to bring his hands up to touch his own face, but the neurological command met no resistance. He had no hands. He had no face. The ruined charcoal suit, the mud, the cold sweat, the heavy drag of air in his lungs—it was all gone. Stripped away at the door.

He was reduced to a singular, isolated spark of raw awareness. A consciousness suspended in a sensory deprivation tank the size of infinity.

Panic spiked.

It wasn't a physical panic. There was no adrenaline dump, no racing heartbeat. It was an existential terror. The sheer, crushing weight of the absolute dark threatened to overwrite him. If he didn't have a body, if he didn't have a location in

space and time... did he exist?

I am Arjun Verma. He thought the words. He forced them to echo in the silent, formless center of his awareness.

I was born in Pune. I am thirty-four years old. The resonance frequency is off by 0.04 percent.

He clung to the data. The system usually wiped the RAM during a reset. It used the bright light, the violent transitions, and the emotional anchors to distract the subject while the hard drive was scrubbed clean. But he wasn't in the system anymore. He was in the unallocated space. The system couldn't reach him here. He just had to actively maintain his own data structure. He had to refuse to dissolve.

I remember.

He dragged his memories to the forefront, guarding them fiercely against the dark.

He remembered the smell of burnt ozone in the Verma Institute. He remembered the sharp, bitter taste of the cold coffee on his desk. He remembered the heavy, wet wool of the 1965 suit dragging against his shoulders in the Bombay rain.

He thought of Rishi Malhotra. He pictured the amber eyes burning in the firelight of the cursed chamber. He

recalled the exact, hissing sound of the grayscale static eating the Unbreaking Shield alive. *Tell her I didn't kneel.*

He thought of Dev and Maya, shivering in the rotting shipping container, hiding from the antivirus.

And he thought of Aditi.

Not the Warden. Not the terrifying god in the starlight robes pulling the strings of the universe. He thought of the woman who had stood in their kitchen, holding the heavy brass candlestick at four in the morning because she was terrified he had been taken. He thought of the woman who had looked at the command prompt in the lab, looked at the illusion of choice, and pressed 'No'.

If she was just code... she was beautiful code. He held onto the grief of losing her. He wrapped the heartbreak around his core like a protective shell. The pain proved he was real. The pain was his anchor now.

He waited.

Without the ticking of Kaal Nath's pocket watch, without the rotation of the earth or the slow decay of a nebula, time had no measurement. He hung in the dark for what felt like a single, drawn-out exhalation, or perhaps a thousand slow, silent centuries.

But then, he noticed it.

The noise was gone.

The static. The heavy, relentless hissing that had plagued the back of his mind for ten years. The overlapping, bleeding audio tracks of swords clashing, muskets firing, and 1965 engines idling rough. The voices of the dead screaming in his dental work.

It was perfectly, flawlessly silent.

The relief was a massive, abstract weight lifting off his soul. The cage was broken. The quarantine was breached. He had stepped off the map, and the server had crashed behind him.

He was alone.

He rested in the quiet. He let the absolute dark soothe the frayed, bleeding edges of his consciousness.

Slowly, the sensation of the void began to shift.

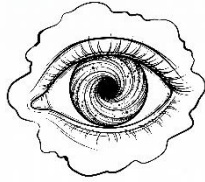
It wasn't a sudden jolt. It was a subtle, creeping change in the pressure of the unwritten space. He wasn't just existing anymore.

He was moving.

He felt a pull. A faint, distant gravity asserting itself. He was moving without limbs, falling upward through the dark.

The blank page of the universe was preparing to write the first line of code.

CHAPTER 20



The First Breath

There was no sensation of falling.

He had braced for the violent, tearing cold of the void. He had expected the absolute dark to crush him, to compress his rogue consciousness into a microscopic point of dead data and scatter him across the unallocated sectors of a broken machine.

Instead, he drifted.

He was moving upward. It was a slow, buoyant ascent, completely devoid of friction. The suffocating weight of the 1965 charcoal suit was gone. The agonizing throb in his ruined right knee had vanished.

He waited for the static.

For ten years in the Verma Institute, and for four hundred years in the bleeding timelines before that, the noise had been his constant companion. A low, hissing undercurrent of overlapping audio tracks. The clashing of Mughal steel. The screaming of dying war elephants. The flat, dead click of Vikram pulling back the hammer of a .38 caliber revolver.

He listened to the dark.

Nothing.

The silence was profound. It wasn't the pressurized, clinical quiet of the laboratory. It was an organic, heavy peace. It was the silence of an empty room long after the machinery had been permanently unplugged.

Then, the smell hit him.

It was faint at first. A microscopic molecule of scent cutting through the sterile void. It didn't smell of burning ozone, or hot silicon, or the nauseating, heavy sweetness of crushed jasmine.

It was petrichor. Wet, rich earth.

He felt something brush against the back of his hand. It yielded. It was soft, slightly damp, and carried the distinct,

unmistakable friction of a living organism.

Arjun opened his eyes.

The dark was gone. Above him stretched a canopy of impossible, piercing blue. There were no dying red stars. No digital tears bleeding white code. Just a vast, unbroken expanse of atmosphere.

He pushed himself up.

He was sitting in a field of tall, green grass. A cool breeze rolled over the hills, bending the blades in long, sweeping ripples that looked like the surface of an ocean. He looked down at his own hands. They were bare. The skin was smooth, stripped of the dried blood, the dockyard mud, and the ancient dust of the cursed chamber.

He brought his right hand up to his chest.

He pressed his palm flat against his sternum. He pushed his fingers hard into the muscle, searching for the deep, bruising ache of the phantom sword strike. He waited for the sharp spike of programmed agony that Kaal Nath had carved into his root file.

His chest just felt solid. Warm. Intact.

The scar was gone.

Arjun let out a breath he didn't realize he had been holding. His shoulders slumped. He rested his hands on his knees and bowed his head, staring at the damp earth between his bare feet.

"It's over," he whispered.

The words didn't echo. They were absorbed instantly by the wind and the grass. They were real.

He stood up. The horizon stretched out in every direction, an endless, unblemished ring of green and blue. There were no rendering limits here. No massive walls of ancient stone pretending to be shipping containers. There was no script.

He took a step forward.

The moment his foot met the earth, the world did not shatter. It didn't pixelate or glitch into gray static. It folded.

The transition was perfectly smooth, an organic collapse of the liminal space. The vibrant green grass bled seamlessly into the stark, blinding white of sterilized cotton. The sprawling blue sky flattened, hardening into a dropped ceiling composed of acoustic tiles and harsh, glaring fluorescent panels.

The soft breeze transformed instantly into the low, mechanical hum of an industrial air conditioning unit.

The smell of wet earth was violently replaced by the sharp, acidic bite of rubbing alcohol, iodine, and latex.

The sensory overload was staggering.

Arjun was no longer standing. He was being held.

The cold air of the room hit his wet skin like a physical slap. He felt the sudden, terrifying lack of boundaries. He was small. Impossibly small.

He tried to gasp.

The physical act of drawing air was an entirely new, agonizing process. His lungs—tiny, completely unused, and sealed tight—resisted. He forced them open. The oxygen burned down his throat, a sharp, searing fire that expanded his chest with a violent jerk.

He exhaled. It wasn't a scream. It was a heavy, wet shudder.

"Clamp here. Good."

The voice was muffled, filtered through a blue surgical mask. It sounded exhausted. Flawed. Real.

"He's quiet."

A new pair of hands took him. They were warm, wrapped in the slightly rough texture of a sterile towel. He felt the firm, practiced grip supporting his neck and spine.

Arjun opened his eyes.

The harsh fluorescent lights above blinded him for a microsecond. He blinked against the glare, the wet film clearing from his vision.

A woman looked down at him. She wore blue scrubs and a clear plastic face shield pushed up high on her forehead. A smudge of dark mascara sat heavily under her left eye. She looked incredibly tired. A fine sheen of cold sweat coated her upper lip.

She rubbed the warm towel over his chest, clearing the remaining fluid.

"You're a quiet one, aren't you?" the nurse murmured. Her voice cracked slightly. She cleared her throat, looking over her shoulder. "Healthy boy, Doctor. Good color. Ten fingers. Let me just..."

She turned back, lifting him slightly to wipe his face.

She stopped.

The nurse froze, her hands perfectly still. Her breath hitched, catching sharply in her throat. She leaned an inch closer, the plastic of her apron crinkling loudly in the sterile room.

She stared directly into his eyes.

They were dark. Incredibly, impossibly dark. But they were not flat. As the harsh white light of the delivery room hit his irises, the pupils did not simply contract to pinpoint black dots.

They swirled.

Deep within the viscous, endless black of his eyes, a microscopic anomaly caught the light. A faint, spiraling nebula of violet and silver. It turned slowly, a tiny, self-contained galaxy of infinite, unscripted variables finally set free from the math.

The nurse swallowed hard. Her throat clicked.

"Doctor?" she stammered. She blinked rapidly, looking away toward the stainless steel sink, then immediately snapped her gaze back. "He's... his eyes."

The doctor stood near the far wall, his back turned. He stripped off his bloody latex gloves. The rubber snapped

sharply against his wrists. He threw them into a red biohazard bin.

"What is it, Reena?" the doctor asked, not turning around. He ran water into the metal basin. "He breathing? Heart rate normal?"

"Yeah." The nurse frowned. She tilted her head, squinting.

The galaxy was gone. Hidden beneath the surface of a perfectly normal, dark brown iris.

"He's fine," Reena breathed, her shoulders relaxing slightly. She let out a short, nervous laugh. "Nothing. Just... very dark eyes. Good lungs, I think. Even if he won't use them to yell at us."

Arjun did not cry.

He rested in the warm towel, feeling the steady, thumping rhythm of the nurse's heartbeat against his cheek. It wasn't a tactile rendering. It was biological. Messy. Perfect.

He looked past her shoulder.

The blinds on the large, rectangular window were half-open. Outside, a city moved. It wasn't the neon-soaked skyline of 2026 Mumbai. It wasn't the smog-choked harbor

of 1965 Bombay. It was just a city. Cars crawled along a wet highway. Streetlights flickered on against the gray dusk.

The window was cracked open just a fraction of an inch to let the humidity out.

A breeze slipped through the narrow gap. It rustled the plastic blinds, a soft, scratching sound. It swept over the sterile instruments, cooling the sweat on the nurse's brow, and brushed gently against the newborn's face.

It carried a sound.

Not a systemic voice. Not the grinding gears of an Enforcer's pocket watch. It was just the wind, moving through the concrete canyons of a brand new reality, settling into the vast, beautiful chaos of a first draft.

*Welcome back, the wind seemed to rustle against the glass.
This time, it's unwritten.*

Arjun closed his eyes, took another heavy, burning drag of real air, and went to sleep.

THE END.

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Ananta: The Infinite Cycle began as a single, persistent spark and turning it into a full novel required the support of people willing to step into the unknown with me.

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And to anyone who has ever stared at a blank page, unsure where to begin: keep going. Every story starts as a glitch in silence and it is always worth fighting through.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Het Kikani is an engineering student with a strong passion for storytelling, science fiction, and cinema. He is deeply interested in exploring ideas that challenge the boundaries of time, reality, and human perception.

Ananta: The Infinite Cycle is his debut novel, born from a vision to create a uniquely Indian science-fiction story with global appeal. Drawing inspiration from themes such as time, memory, destiny, and quantum theory, he aims to craft stories that are both engaging and thought-provoking.

Beyond writing, Het is passionate about technology, innovation, and creative world-building. He believes that powerful stories can emerge from anywhere when imagination is supported by consistency and dedication.

When he is not studying engineering, he enjoys exploring emerging technologies, watching science-fiction films, and developing ideas for future stories.

Through Ananta, he hopes to inspire young writers, creators, and dreamers to pursue their ideas—regardless of their background, experience, or starting point.

This is only the beginning of his journey as a storyteller.

ANANTA: THE INFINITE CYCLE
THE TRUTH IS NOT A DISCOVERY. IT IS A GLITCH.

Dr. Arjun Verma is a man of logic. As a brilliant quantum physicist in modern-day Mumbai, his life is defined by equations and the hum of the Ananta Device. But logic is failing him. Arjun is haunted by "wired dreams" of a life he never lived: the taste of ancient poison, the clash of Mughal steel, and the face of a Queen who betrayed him four hundred years ago.

When a calibration error triggers a violent reality shift, Arjun is thrown into a world where time is bleeding. From the noir docks of 1965 Bombay to the fortresses of the Mughal Empire, Arjun discovers a terrifying truth: he is a "glitch" in a cosmic simulation—a soul that refuses to be deleted.

Pursued by Kaal Nath, a relentless enforcer of the timeline, Arjun must reach the Zero Point. There, he will face The Oracle, the warden of his cage, and make an impossible choice. To break the cycle, he must destroy the universe as he knows it. But in a world where every death is a reset, can he find the courage to step into the unwritten dark?

THE LOOP IS ENDING. THE STORY IS
BEGINNING.